

Age of Iron



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF J. M. COETZEE

Coetzee was born in Cape Town to Afrikaner parents. His father was a soldier during his childhood and was rarely present. Coetzee attended Catholic school before moving on to the University of Cape Town where he studied mathematics and English. Coetzee graduated college with a dual degree and then worked for IBM as a programmer in the early 1960s. He also received a Master of Arts degree in 1963, also from the University of Cape Town. Then, in 1965, Coetzee traveled to the United States and studied at the University of Texas at Austin, where he received his PhD in English literature. Coetzee began writing fiction in 1968 while working on his PhD and eventually published his first novel, *Dusklands*, in 1974. Coetzee followed up his debut with *In the Heart of the Country* in 1977, before publishing his first major novel, [Waiting for the Barbarians](#), in 1980. [Waiting for the Barbarians](#) brought Coetzee international acclaim, and he followed it up with two of his most famous novels, *Life & Times of Michael K* and *Foe*. In the late 1990s, Coetzee published his first autobiographical novel, *Boyhood: Scenes from Provincial Life*, as well as his most critically acclaimed novel, [Disgrace](#). He immigrated to Australia in 2002, and he still lives there today. Today, Coetzee is South Africa's best-known writer, as well as one of the most decorated novelists in the world. He won the Nobel Prize for Literature in 2003 and has continued to produce influential and critically acclaimed work ever since.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Age of Iron takes place during Apartheid in South Africa. Apartheid was a system of racial segregation and discrimination that the South African government enforced from 1948 until the mid 1990s. Under Apartheid, the South African population was classified into racial groups, with white South Africans holding significant political power and privileges, while non-white South Africans, especially Black people, were subjected to severe racial discrimination, economic inequality, and political disenfranchisement. Notably, the 1980s witnessed a significant increase in resistance against apartheid. The African National Congress, led by figures like Nelson Mandela, played a crucial role in organizing protests and anti-Apartheid activities both within South Africa and on the international stage. Resistance was met with attempts at violent suppression from the South African government, and the violence grew more intense the longer Apartheid dragged on. *Age of Iron* takes place during an unspecified time period toward the end of Apartheid, when the violence was at its peak.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Nearly all of J. M. Coetzee's novels deal with the issue of Apartheid in South Africa. Perhaps the most famous of his works to do so is [Disgrace](#), the story of a white South African professor navigating post-Apartheid South Africa after ruining his reputation and losing his job. Coetzee won the Booker Prize for [Disgrace](#) and for *Life & Times of Michael K*, a novel that depicts an imagined civil war during Apartheid. Other contemporary South African writers have also tackled the issue of Apartheid, including Damon Galgut and Nadine Gordimer. Galgut's most notable novel—and also his most recent—is *The Promise*, which tells a decades-long story of one family's experience in Apartheid and post-Apartheid South Africa. Meanwhile, Gordimer is primarily known for her anti-Apartheid novels *Burger's Daughter* and [July's People](#), which the South African government banned because of their politics. All of these works are also part of a larger body of world literature focused on atrocity. Other books in this tradition include works of Holocaust literature, such as Elie Wiesel's [Night](#) and Thomas Keneally's *Schindler's Ark* (published as [Schindler's List](#) in the United States).

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Age of Iron
- **When Written:** 1990
- **Where Written:** Cape Town, South Africa
- **When Published:** 1990
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Epistolary Novel, South African Literature
- **Setting:** Cape Town, South Africa
- **Climax:** When the police show up at Mrs. Curren's house looking for John, Mrs. Curren tries to convince them to leave John alone. However, the police end up shooting and killing John.
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Repeat Winner. J. M. Coetzee is one of only four writers to win the Booker Prize twice. The others are Margaret Atwood, Peter Carey, and Hilary Mantel.

Animal Advocate. In recent years, Coetzee's fiction and political activism has turned toward animal rights. Coetzee is a vocal vegetarian and has participated in several campaigns aimed at stopping cruelty to animals.



PLOT SUMMARY

Age of Iron begins with Mrs. Curren learning of her terminal **cancer** diagnosis. This personal crisis is set against the broader crisis of Apartheid, which she has largely ignored in her life of academic privilege as a Classics professor. The novel takes the form of letters that Mrs. Curren writes to her daughter, who lives in America and whom Mrs. Curren doesn't want to tell about her illness. She hopes her letters will reach her daughter after she dies, and that they'll help her daughter understand both Mrs. Curren's final weeks and Apartheid.

When Mrs. Curren arrives home from her oncology appointment, she discovers a homeless man, Vercueil, sleeping outside her home. At first, Mrs. Curren tries to send Vercueil away. However, they soon begin a friendship, and Mrs. Curren pays Vercueil to do some chores around the house. Usually, Vercueil only does half of what Mrs. Curren asks him, but she still pays him anyway.

After Mrs. Curren gets used to Vercueil's presence, her housekeeper, Florence, returns from Guguletu, where she has been living with her children. Florence brings her teenage son, Bheki, back with her because the schools in Guguletu have closed due to the large-scale violence occurring there. Bheki is a teenager who wants to be involved in the resistance, and he begins bringing his friend, John, around the house, which makes Mrs. Curren uncomfortable. One day, Bheki and John have a dangerous encounter with the police, which lands John in the hospital. The event is a wake-up call to Mrs. Curren, who cannot believe how poorly law enforcement treats Black South Africans. Following this, Bheki becomes increasingly radicalized, and he goes to Guguletu to join the resistance. Florence and Mrs. Curren go looking for him, only to find him dead.

Meanwhile, the relationship between Mrs. Curren and Vercueil continues to evolve. Initially, Vercueil is a disheveled, often inebriated drifter, but he gradually becomes a constant companion to Mrs. Curren. He listens to her fears about death and her reflections on a life lived in a deeply divided country. Still, his character remains an enigma: sometimes he seems like her guardian angel, while at other times he appears violent and menacing.

After being discharged from the hospital following his encounter with law enforcement, John returns to Mrs. Curren's home. John wants to go to Guguletu, but Mrs. Curren insists that he stay put for the time being, so he does not end up dead. She tries to contact people who might help him, but no one comes. Mrs. Curren becomes increasingly worried when she learns that John is stashing guns in her house. One day, the police come knocking on Mrs. Curren's door, looking for John. Mrs. Curren tries to protect John, but she fails: the police knock down John's door and kill him. The incident leaves Mrs.

Curren delirious, and she goes wandering out into the streets. There, young people assault and mug her while she is still in a dazed state. Luckily, Vercueil finds her and returns her to her home.

As Mrs. Curren's illness advances, her reflections become more introspective and philosophical. She grapples with the meaning of her life and her role in a society riddled with injustice. Her narrative is punctuated by her attempts to reconcile with her daughter, who remains a distant figure because she has started her own life in America and does not plan to return to South Africa until Apartheid is over. Mrs. Curren begins spending more time with Vercueil and even invites him to sleep in her bed to help keep her warm. Vercueil does what he can to keep Mrs. Curren as comfortable as possible and promises to help her end her life when the time comes. One night, Mrs. Curren wakes up to find cold air blowing into her room. Vercueil is standing on the balcony letting the air blow into the bedroom. Mrs. Curren asks Vercueil, "Is it time?" Rather than respond, Vercueil climbs in bed and violently embraces her. His embrace feels cold.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Mrs. Curren – Mrs. Curren is a retired classics professor residing in Cape Town, South Africa, during the Apartheid era. At the beginning of the novel, Dr. Syfret diagnoses her with terminal **cancer**, a condition that forces her to confront not only her mortality but also the harsh realities of the society she inhabits. Throughout the novel, Mrs. Curren undergoes a profound transformation. Initially detached from the political turmoil around her, her illness and subsequent interactions—particularly with her housekeeper Florence and Florence's son Bheki—gradually awaken her to the brutalities and injustices of Apartheid. This awakening is both painful and enlightening, leading her to reassess her own complicity in Apartheid and the moral responsibilities she has as a privileged and white South African. The story is told through a series of letters that Mrs. Curren is writing to her daughter in America. Mrs. Curren loves her daughter and understands why she left for America, but also resents her for it. She feels that her daughter has abandoned her and left her to die alone, even though she refuses to tell her daughter about her illness. Eventually, Mrs. Curren finds some peace after becoming close with Vercueil and forming a strange companionship with him.

Vercueil – Vercueil is an enigmatic homeless man who unexpectedly enters Mrs. Curren's life. Mrs. Curren initially perceives his presence as intrusive and unwelcome, but as the narrative unfolds, he becomes her closest friend and companion. Vercueil's background remains largely a mystery. Coetzee describes him as disheveled, often inebriated, and

living on the fringes of society. However, notably, there are no references to his race. As Mrs. Curren confronts her mortality, Vercueil becomes a constant, albeit unconventional, companion. Despite his rough exterior and seeming apathy, Vercueil exhibits moments of surprising empathy and understanding. Toward the end of the novel, he promises Mrs. Curren that he will help her end her life whenever she feels she is ready. Although there is something disturbing about his offer—especially because he often seems a bit too eager to carry it out—Mrs. Curren appreciates his presence and develops a profound connection with him.

Bheki – Bheki is the son of Mrs. Curren’s housekeeper, Florence; he represents the new generation of Black South Africans deeply affected by the injustices of the Apartheid regime. The novel introduces him as a rebellious teenager with a strong desire for social justice. Although Mrs. Curren assumes he is too young and naïve to understand what he is getting himself into, she appears mistaken in her judgement. Bheki knows exactly how dangerous and important the fight against Apartheid is for his future, which is why he dedicates himself to the cause. Unfortunately, his resistance results in his brutal death: police kill him in Guguletu.

John (Bheki’s Friend) – John is a friend who Bheki starts bringing around Mrs. Curren’s home. Mrs. Curren does not like John; he is rude and, in her mind, likely to bring trouble. Still, Bheki brings him around anyway, leading to confrontation with the police, which lands John in the hospital. When John gets out of the hospital, he returns to Mrs. Curren’s home, where he stashes guns. One day, the police come knocking on Mrs. Curren’s door looking for John and, when they find him, they kill him.

Mr. Thabane – Mr. Thabane is Florence’s cousin who Mrs. Curren meets in Guguletu. He is a former schoolteacher who now dedicates his time and energy to fighting against the Apartheid regime. He and Mrs. Curren debate several times over the course of the novel about the role that young people should play in stopping Apartheid. Mrs. Curren thinks young people should stay away from the conflict as much as possible. Meanwhile, Mr. Thabane thinks they have no choice but to fight.

Florence – Florence is a housekeeper for the protagonist, Mrs. Curren, and appears to singlehandedly care for her three children (her husband, William, appears only in a flashback, and it’s unclear if he’s still in her life). Although she is generally a soft-spoken woman, Florence is willing to speak out against Mrs. Curren when she expresses her ignorance regarding what it is like for Black South Africans under Apartheid. She is also a protective mother who does everything she can for her children in a way that wishes to oppress and possibly kill them.

Hope and Beauty – Hope and Beauty are Florence’s daughters. Their names offer a symbolic counterpoint to the brutality and despair of the Apartheid regime; they represent the beauty and

hopefulness of South Africa’s future rather than its morally bankrupt and cruel present. Hope and Beauty are minor characters in the novel, perhaps because hope and beauty are hard to come by under the Apartheid regime. However, their few appearances are symbolically notable. In particular, when Mrs. Curren travels with Florence to Guguletu to search for Bheki, she leaves Hope and Beauty behind—literally and metaphorically—before stepping out into the ravaged streets of the city. What she sees is Guguletu makes Mrs. Curren wonder if there is any hope and beauty left to salvage.

Mrs. Curren’s Daughter – Mrs. Curren’s daughter never appears in the novel. However, the letters that make up the novel from Mrs. Curren are addressed to her. From Mrs. Curren’s letters, it is clear that she lives in America and has a family. She left South Africa as a form of protest against the Apartheid regime.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Dr. Syfret – Dr. Syfret is Mrs. Curren’s oncologist. After receiving her terminal diagnosis, Mrs. Curren refuses to see him in person and only calls to request more medicine.

Mrs. Curren’s Husband – This character never appears in the novel. He was married to Mrs. Curren for a long time, but they divorced prior to his death in the 1970s.

William – William is Florence’s husband. His job is to slaughter chickens.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



VIOLENCE AND PERSPECTIVE

Age of Iron takes place during Apartheid in South Africa. Apartheid was South Africa’s government-enforced system of racial segregation, which systemically oppressed Black South Africans. The Apartheid regime disgusts the novel’s white protagonist Mrs. Curren, though she does not realize the extent of its depravity until she witnesses the violence it brings firsthand. Because Mrs. Curren lives away from Guguletu—which turns into a warzone over the course of the novel—she manages to distance herself from the atrocities going on in the country. Because she is white, she does not experience police discrimination the same way her Black counterparts do, and the news does not share what is actually going on in the country. As such, although she is morally opposed to Apartheid, Mrs. Curren can live her life

relatively comfortable and guilt-free.

However, Mrs. Curren's world is turned upside-down after she takes a trip to Guguletu to look for housekeeper Florence's son, Bheki. Bheki no longer goes to school because his hometown is a warzone. Instead, he has taken up arms to fight against the police who wish to oppress Black South Africans. In Guguletu, Mrs. Curren finds complete and utter chaos. Everywhere she looks, the police are committing atrocities—homes are burned down, people are killed and left homeless, and no one is held responsible. Eventually, she and Florence discover that police murdered Bheki, along with four other Black boys. From this moment forward, Mrs. Curren can no longer look at her country the same way. Her life is permanently changed and, though she is close to death, she spends much of the time she has left reflecting on what will become of South Africa's Black citizens. Mrs. Curren's experience suggests that it's impossible to fully comprehend the violence and oppression that other people suffer without witnessing or experiencing it firsthand.



PAIN, SUFFERING, AND COMPANIONSHIP

Mrs. Curren, the central character in *Age of Iron*, has recently been diagnosed with terminal cancer when the novel begins. She knows she does not have much time left to live, and that she will be in increasing amounts of unbearable pain for the rest of her life. In addition to her physical pain, Mrs. Curren also suffers from the mental and emotional pain of feeling as though her daughter and country have abandoned her. She lives out her final weeks full of regret and wondering if her life could have gone differently. However, despite how terrible her life has become, Mrs. Curren manages to find some solace in her peculiar friendship with Vercueil, a homeless man whom she befriends and eventually lets into her home. Although Vercueil often frustrates Mrs. Curren, she appreciates his presence. She feels that she can talk to him openly and honestly—even if he does not always listen—and depend on him to keep her safe. Although Vercueil is not always the kindest caretaker, he provides Mrs. Curren with some much-needed companionship at the end of her life, especially when she is in great pain.

Of course, Mrs. Curren isn't the only character who suffers. Vercueil himself begins the novel without a home and spends every waking hour drinking, and he suggests he does so to dull the trauma his painful past has caused. Meanwhile, the Black citizens of Cape Town suffer from the emotional, mental, and physical pain that the Apartheid regime inflicts upon them on a daily basis. Mr. Thabane, one of Florence's cousins, suggests that one of things that keeps Black people in Cape Town hopeful is the notion of "comradeship." Although Mrs. Curren is skeptical of his claim because she worries that comradeship only results in more pain and suffering, Mr. Thabane assures her that feeling like part of a community is necessary for Black

people to keep going in such an oppressive landscape. As such, the novel seems to suggest that perhaps the only solution to pain and suffering is the comfort one can find in the presence of other people, especially those whom one loves or who are going through the exact same traumatic experiences.



APARTHEID IN SOUTH AFRICA

The Age of Iron takes place during the Apartheid regime in South Africa, during which the government upheld a system of racial segregation and brutally oppressed Black South Africans. The white South African government forced Black people to live in squalor, while the majority of white people lived in relative comfort. *Age of Iron* illustrates how, during Apartheid, two different realities exist for white and Black citizens. Although some white citizens, like Mrs. Curren, are sympathetic to the plight of Black people, they fundamentally do not comprehend how different life is for their Black counterparts. For instance, well-meaning Mrs. Curren twice tries to help John, a Black teenager, by getting him help from the police or at the local hospital. Mrs. Curren doesn't believe her Black housekeeper, Florence, that the police will only make things worse—and Florence turns out to be correct; the police refuse to help. And John is taken to a subpar hospital for serious injuries, where he gets inadequate care. While Florence is enraged by these occurrences like Mrs. Curren is, she isn't surprised. The reason Mrs. Curren is able to ignore the extent of the racism that exists in her country for so long is because the South African government makes sure that white and Black people live in two separate realities. Every institution in the country is set up to benefit white people, to the detriment of Black people. By presenting the story through Mrs. Curren's perspective, the novel illustrates how systems like Apartheid can blind those who benefit from structural inequality to that inequality, simply because their experiences are so wildly different from those who suffer under those systems.



THE VALUE OF WRITING AND LITERATURE

Age of Iron is made up of a series of letters that Mrs. Curren writes to her daughter in America. As such, the entire novel is filtered through Mrs. Curren's perspective. Although her letters are open and honest, it's also important to keep in mind that she's an unreliable narrator; that is, as her letters come from her perspective, they are naturally biased and reflect how she thinks about things more than they reflect the truth. Although there are reasons to be skeptical of Mrs. Curren's descriptions—after all, the story is, in part, about the limitations of white people to comprehend Apartheid in South Africa—the novel suggests that there's still value and power in Mrs. Curren's writing, and indeed, in literature more broadly. For one, writing helps Mrs. Curren process her situation, both

her impending death and her burgeoning understanding of Apartheid and its horrors. It then helps her connect with her daughter, who will, Mrs. Curren hopes, read the letters after Mrs. Curren dies and better understand her mother's final weeks.

A former Classics professor, Mrs. Curren uses numerous references to classic writers and works to make sense of events happening around her. For instance, she considers the Athenian historian Thucydides and his writing on war after witnessing the "warzone" of Guguletu. This reference in particular illustrates how Mrs. Curren can better understand this conflict happening in her present thanks to writing on similar subjects from centuries ago. With this, *Age of Iron* suggests that writing and literature—from classic works from more than a thousand years ago to the novel itself—have the unique ability to teach empathy and understanding to both readers and writers.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



CANCER

Age of Iron uses Mrs. Curren's battle with cancer as a symbol for the larger societal and moral decay present in South Africa under Apartheid. Just as cancer corrupts the body from within, the novel illustrates how the Apartheid system corrupts South African society, eroding its moral and ethical foundations. This symbolism extends to the physical and emotional suffering that cancer causes, which echos the pain and trauma people suffer due to systemic oppression and widespread violence. In large part, *Age of Iron* is a book about empathy, and it is only through the physical decay of her body that Mrs. Curren can understand the societal decay that is happening all around her. Notably, Mrs. Curren's cancer is terminal, and it is implied that she is on death's door as the novel concludes. This seems to suggest that Apartheid, too, is in its final days.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 3

Explanation and Analysis

This passage is from the opening of the novel, as Mrs. Curren arrives home from her oncologist, who just told her she has terminal cancer. The alley, which was once alive with the sounds of play and the presence of children, has become desolate, demonstrating the transformations that time brings—not just to physical spaces but to lives and societies. The alley's current state as "a dead place, waste, without use" suggests neglect and abandonment. The accumulation of rotting leaves showcases the natural cycle of life and death, but in the context of the novel (set against the backdrop of apartheid South Africa) also alludes to the deterioration of the country's social and moral structures. The contrast between the alley's past—filled with the innocence of children at play—and its present—marked by uselessness and decay—evoke a sense of nostalgia and loss. These images especially resonate with Mrs. Curren who feels that she herself is rotting and dying after receiving her cancer diagnosis.

“The first task laid on me, from today: to resist the craving to share my death. Loving you, loving life, to forgive the living and take my leave without bitterness. To embrace death as my own, mine alone.

To whom this writing then? The answer: to you but not to you; to me; to you in me.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Mrs. Curren's Daughter

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 6

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Mrs. Curren lays out the goal of the novel; she is writing a series of letters to her daughter, which she will only give to her daughter after she has died of cancer. Her words convey the sense of responsibility she feels to



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Penguin Books edition of *Age of Iron* published in 1998.

Chapter 1 Quotes

“There is an alley down the side of the garage, you may remember it, you and your friends would sometimes play there. Now it is a dead place, waste, without use, where windblown leaves pile up and rot.

bear the weight of their dying alone. There is an implication that death, although a universal experience, is ultimately a solitary journey, and she does not desire to not burden others with the emotional toll of her passing. Here, she is quite straightforward in this proclamation, though her feelings waver as the novel progresses.

This passage also references the importance of writing. Mrs. Curren's answer to whom she is writing to reflects the nature of writing as a form of communication that can be both personal and impersonal. It implies that the writing is a means of dialogue with the self, as well as with one's eventual readers. Because she cannot (or will not) talk to her daughter in person about what she is going through, she feels the need to have an imaginary conversation with herself to process her feelings.

Who deserves anything? In a quick fury I thrust the purse at him. "What do you believe in, then? Taking? Taking what you want? Go on: take!"

Calmly he took the purse, emptied it of thirty rand and some coins, and handed it back. Then off he went, the dog jauntily at his heels. In half an hour he was back; I heard the clink of bottles.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 21

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Mrs. Curren lectures Vercueil, who she thinks is trying to leech off of her without giving her anything in return. According to Mrs. Curren's worldview, Vercueil is the worst type of person because he lacks what she sees as a universal moral principle. When she shoves her purse at Vercueil, she does not suspect he will take anything from it. However, contrary to her assumption, he not only takes her money, but he uses it to buy alcohol. This passage demonstrates that Mrs. Curren and Vercueil live in two separate worlds. Mrs. Curren behaves according to a traditional moral code that she views as totally correct and the only way to be. Meanwhile, Vercueil is living in the new South Africa, where traditional moral codes are questioned or have broken down. His behavior makes Mrs. Curren confront the idea that life does not operate on a system of meritocracy where people get what (she believes) they deserve. In his worldview, it is necessary to take what one

needs in order to survive without any concern for petty morality.

“[...] Charity: from the Latin word for the heart. It is as hard to receive as to give. It takes as much effort. I wish you would learn that. I wish you would learn something instead of just lying around.”

A lie: charity, *caritas*, has nothing to do with the heart. But what does it matter if my sermons rest on false etymologies? He barely listens when I speak to him. Perhaps, despite those keen bird-eyes, he is more befuddled with drink than I know. Or perhaps, finally, he does not care. Care: the true root of charity. I look for him to care, and he does not. Because he is beyond caring. Beyond caring and beyond care.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 22

Explanation and Analysis

This moment is a continuation of Mrs. Curren's conversation with Vercueil about the ethics of giving and taking. To Mrs. Curren, the idea that one needs to work for a living and only take (or, more likely, accept something offered) after one has given something in return is self-evident. However, Vercueil challenges her notion of giving and taking, which makes her uncomfortable. Although she accuses Vercueil of abandoning common morality, she does the same thing in this passage. In the same way that stealing is considered immoral in Mrs. Curren's traditional worldview, so is lying, which is exactly what she does here. Mrs. Curren lies to Vercueil about the etymology of the word "charity" because she knows he will believe whatever she tells him (although whether he cares is a different story). Mrs. Curren might tell herself that her "false etymologies" make no difference, but she is violating the same principles she claims to uphold, while chastising Vercueil for behaving similarly.

I played as badly as ever, misreading the same chords as half a century ago, repeating fingering mistakes grown by now into the bone, never to be corrected. (The bones prized above all archaeologists, I remember, are those gnarled with disease or splintered by an arrowhead: bones marked with a history from a time before history.)

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 23

Explanation and Analysis

After Mrs. Curren's quarrel with Vercueil over the nature of giving and taking, she sits down to play the piano, knowing that Vercueil is listening to her outside. In this passage, the novel draws an analogy, using the physical evidence of a life's experiences found in bones and the ingrained mistakes made in playing music to talk about human imperfection and the ways in which personal histories define people. Just as the bones with the most interesting stories are those that have been marked by hardship (violent hardship, in particular), so too are the lives of people. The errors and the challenges people face leave indelible marks on their character and become an integral part of them.

In Mrs. Curren's case, bones have a special significance because she has bone cancer, meaning that she will one day be the type of specimen that archaeologists prize. But she also seems to recognize how distant and dehumanizing this is: at some point in the distant future, the only thing important about her will be the fact that she died of cancer and thus had interesting bones; nobody will know or care about any of the other aspects of her life.

Chapter 2 Quotes

☝☝ Last year, when the troubles in the schools began, I spoke my mind to Florence. "In my day we considered education a privilege," I said. "Parents would scrimp and save to keep their children in school. We would have thought it madness to burn a school down."

"It is different today," replied Florence.

"Do you approve of children burning down their schools?"

"I cannot tell these children what to do," said Florence. "It is all changed today. There are no more mothers and fathers."

"That is nonsense," I said. "There are always mothers and fathers." On that note our exchange ended.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren, Florence (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 38-39

Explanation and Analysis

This is one of the first exchanges that Mrs. Curren has with Florence after she and her children return from Guguletu, where the violence and chaos has become overwhelming. Their conversation reflects generational and racial divides (Florence is a Black South African) regarding the complexities of parental authority in times of social upheaval. Because Mrs. Curren is not attuned to what is happening with Black South Africans in her country, she is fine with adhering to a traditional moral framework, and she either doesn't know or refuses to accept that times have changed. She has no reason to question the values she has always held, so she doesn't. Meanwhile, Florence's statements suggest that the times have changed and with it, the nature of the relationships between parents and their children. To Florence, the state of South Africa under apartheid has made it difficult and perhaps even counterproductive for parents to behave how they once did. Florence does not like that she has to raise her children without "mothers and fathers," but her social conditions make her feel like she has no choice. Additionally, saying that there are "no more mothers and fathers" may also allude to deceased mothers and fathers—in some cases, due to the violence caused by apartheid, there may genuinely not be parents to guide children to behave any certain way.

☝☝ The country smoulders, yet with the best will in the world I can only half-attend. My true attention is all inward, upon the thing, the word, the word for the thing inching through my body. An ignominious occupation, and in times like these ridiculous too, as a banker with his clothes on fire is a joke while a burning beggar is not. Yet I cannot help myself. "Look at me!" I want to cry to Florence – "I too am burning!"

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Florence

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 39

Explanation and Analysis

The night Florence and her family return from Guguletu, Mrs. Curren lays in bed thinking of her condition in relation to that of her country. She acknowledges the ongoing strife within South Africa, yet she admits that she is unable to fully engage with it. This reflects a divide between her individual

experience and her broader societal context, suggesting that personal pain can overshadow even the most pervasive public issues.

However, although she is yet to fully realize it, Mrs. Curren's cancer is closely linked to the social context of South Africa. She gets halfway to this epiphany in this passage when she says, "I too am burning!" However, despite recognizing the severity of her country's situation, she feels her own suffering demands more attention. Still, the metaphor of burning unites her personal pain with the country's turmoil. Throughout the novel, Coetzee continues to use the decay of Mrs. Curren's body as an extended metaphor for the condition of South Africa, which is a connection Mrs. Curren pieces together herself later in the story.

☞ Ever since Vercueil took my money he has been drinking; steadily, drinking not only wine but brandy. Some days he does not drink till noon, using the hours of abstinence to make surrender more voluptuous. More often he is intoxicated by the time he leaves the house in mid-morning.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 44-45

Explanation and Analysis

In this excerpt, Vercueil's relationship with alcohol is depicted as a form of escape or surrender, possibly from the harsh realities of life. The implication here is that Vercueil's drinking has intensified or become more reckless after receiving money. This could suggest a lack of restraint or an impulse to seek immediate gratification or relief through alcohol, which can provide a temporary escape from problems or pain. Furthermore, the mention of Vercueil waiting until noon to drink hints at a conscious choice and perhaps a struggle with self-control. Meanwhile, the use of the word "voluptuous" to describe his eventual "surrender" to drinking conveys a sense of indulgence and suggests that he may derive a deeper, more sensuous pleasure from the act because of the anticipation built up during his hours of abstinence. Because of this behavior, the passage implies that Vercueil uses alcohol as a coping mechanism, though the novel never reveals what he is coping with. Certainly, there is the issue of his homeless, but there is also something else in Vercueil's past that the novel hints at but never reveals to the reader.

☞ Children of iron, I thought. Florence herself, too, not unlike iron. The age of iron. After which comes the age of bronze. How long, how long before the softer ages return in their cycle, the age of clay, the age of earth? A Spartan matron, iron-hearted, bearing warrior-sons for the nation. "We are proud of them." We. Come home either with your shield or on your shield.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Florence

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 50

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes during the second conversation Mrs. Curren and Florence have about the status of young people in South African society. It is the passage that gives the novel its title and provides its central metaphor. Here, Mrs. Curren is likening the current generation, represented by Florence and her children, to the Age of Iron. In the Greek poet Hesiod's poem *Works and Days*, in which he lays out the five ages of man, the Iron Age is characterized by toil, misery, violence, and lies—it's the last and worst of the ages of man before the world returns to a golden age. This age is harsh, unforgiving, and requires strength and resilience—qualities that Florence and the children develop in response to the apartheid regime of South Africa.

Mrs. Curren also muses on the cyclical nature of time and the possibility of returning to a softer, more peaceful era. The "age of clay" and the "age of earth" imply a time of malleability, growth, and perhaps gentleness compared to the hard and unyielding age of iron. However, such thoughts resemble the similarly nostalgic and unrealistic thoughts she has about her childhood in South Africa, which are idealized images of the past rather than being either a more nuanced understanding of the past's imperfections or a pragmatic vision of the future.

☞ How easy it is to love a child, how hard to love what a child turns into! Once upon a time, with his fists to his ears and his eyes pinched shut in ecstasy, this creature too floated in a woman's womb, drank of her blood, belly to belly. He too passed through the gates of bone into the radiance outside, was allowed to know mother-love, *amor matris*. Then in the course of time was weaned away from it, made to stand alone, and began to grow dry, stunted, crooked. A life apart, deprived, like all lives; but in this case, surely, more undernourished than most. A man in his middle years still sucking on bottles, yearning for the original bliss, reaching for it in his stupors.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil, Mrs. Curren's Daughter

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 57-58

Explanation and Analysis

Mrs. Curren thinks about the relationship between children and the adults they mature into while listening to Vercueil snore on her couch. To Mrs. Curren, loving a child—an embodiment of innocence and potential—seems natural and uncomplicated. But as a child grows and develops flaws and complexities, that love is tested and can become more difficult to sustain. As this passage is talking about Vercueil, it suggests that, despite being a grown man, Vercueil is still a child; he has simply replaced his mother's milk with bottles of alcohol, which he uses to derive comfort. Mrs. Curren seems to find this both understandable and fundamentally sad.

Notably, Mrs. Curren is saying these words via a letter to her daughter. It is an indirect way for her to acknowledge how she feels about what their relationship has turned into. That is, when she remarks, "how hard to love what a child turns into," she's perhaps acknowledging how much she resents her daughter for leaving South Africa, even if she understands her daughter's reasons for doing so.

☞ "They work with the police," said Bheki. "They are all, the same, the ambulances, the doctors, the police."

"That is nonsense," I said.

"Nobody trusts the ambulance any more. They are always talking to the police on their radios."

"Nonsense."

He smiled a smile not without charm, relishing this chance to lecture me, to tell me about real life. I, the old woman who lived in a shoe, who had no children and didn't know what to do. "It is true," he said—"listen and you will hear."

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren, Bheki (speaker), John (Bheki's Friend), Florence

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 67

Explanation and Analysis

This conversation occurs between Bheki, Florence, and

Mrs. Curren after Mrs. Curren witnesses the police assault Bheki and his friend, seemingly for no reason. Bheki's statement reflects a pervasive sense of paranoia and the belief that various societal institutions are colluding with state forces. In the context of apartheid South Africa, such sentiments were not untrue, given the government's use of state machinery to maintain control and suppress dissent.

Meanwhile, Mrs. Curren's self-referential nursery rhyme allusion paints her as out of touch and ineffective, akin to the character of the rhyme who is overwhelmed by the chaos of her many children. She is somewhat ironically critiquing her perceived ignorance of the complex and painful realities of Black South Africans. However, at this point, she does not know if she is actually in the wrong (and indeed, she believes she's correct and that Bheki is just being condescending). She is sympathetic toward Bheki, but she is still a long way from recognizing just how oppressive the apartheid regime can be for Black South Africans.

☞ "Tell this to your daughter," said Vercueil quietly. "She will come."

"No."

"Tell her right now. Phone her in. America. Tell her you need her here."

"No."

"Then don't tell her afterwards, when it is too late. She won't forgive you."

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren, Vercueil (speaker), Mrs. Curren's Daughter

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 74

Explanation and Analysis

This conversation occurs between Vercueil and Mrs. Curren while they are sitting alone in Mrs. Curren's car. Vercueil wants Mrs. Curren to speak with her daughter about her cancer diagnosis, but Mrs. Curren feels that she shouldn't. Vercueil's words imply a belief in the power of familial bonds and the moral obligation to share life-altering news with loved ones. Although he is usually averse to emotional connection, here he seems to want to help Mrs. Curren renew her relationship with her daughter. In part, he

may be trying to relieve himself of the responsibility of caring for Mrs. Curren, as he is the only one around to help her on a daily basis unless her daughter comes from America. Meanwhile, Mrs. Curren's resistance to speaking with her daughter appears to come from her desire to remain autonomous and not burden her child. She believes that being a mother means she will have to suffer in order to keep her child from suffering. However, as Vercueil's words suggest, Mrs. Curren is going to make her daughter suffer one way or the other—the question is a matter of when, not if.

“Perhaps I should simply accept that that is how one must live from now on: in a state of shame. Perhaps shame is nothing more than the name for the way I feel all the time. The name for the way in which people live who would prefer to be dead.”

Shame. Mortification. Death in life.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), John (Bheki's Friend)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 86

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is an encapsulation of the way Mrs. Curren feels after exiting the police station. She speaks with the police in the hopes of getting justice for the assault she witnessed involving the police and Bheki's friend. However, her experience at the police station makes her realize that justice will never come. Mrs. Curren's resignation to a perpetual state of shame suggests that the circumstances around her have made living an honorable life, as she understands it, impossible. Her statement reflects a loss of hope for change or redemption, as she thinks of shame as a continuous state of being rather than an occasional response to particular events. This also connects to her growing understanding of what, exactly, apartheid entails and the immense violence it brings to Black South Africans. As a white woman who hasn't had to face the truth of what's going on, she now feels immense shame for her inadequate understanding prior to this moment.

Her word choice, and particularly the phrase “death in life,” also link her shameful feelings about her country with her cancer diagnosis. She implies that she feels ashamed of

being ill and burdening people who care for her, which is one of the reasons she insists on staying in her own house—it's one way to avoid as much shame as possible.

Chapter 3 Quotes

“We sat in silence. ‘What are we waiting for?’ I asked. ‘They are sending someone to show us the way.’ A little boy wearing a balaclava cap too large for him came trotting out of the house. With entire self-assurance, greeting us all with a smile, he got into the car and began to give directions. Ten years old at most. A child of the times, at home in this landscape of violence. When I think back to my own childhood. I remember only long sun-struck afternoons, the smell, of dust under avenues of eucalyptus, the quiet rustle of water in roadside furrows, the lulling of doves. A childhood of sleep, prelude, to what was meant to be a life without trouble and a smooth passage to Nirvana. Will we at least be allowed our Nirvana, we children, of that bygone age? I doubt it.”

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 92

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Mrs. Curren contrasts the innocence of her own childhood with the harsh realities faced by the children growing up amid the violence and political turmoil of apartheid-era South Africa. The boy's appearance and demeanor are significant; despite his youth and the oversized balaclava, which suggests he is playing a role that is too big for him, he is confident and assertive. The presence of the balaclava demonstrates the violence and militancy that have infiltrated the lives of incredibly young children. Having come to Guguletu for the first time in a long time, Mrs. Curren identifies the boy as a product of his environment, shaped by the political unrest and conflict that characterize the society in which he's growing up.

The image of the boy in the balaclava is striking in part because of how sharply it contrasts with Mrs. Curren's peaceful and idyllic memories, which evoke a sense of calm and serenity. Through this contrast, the passage reflects on the lost innocence and altered trajectories of lives in a society undergoing violent transformation. It also captures a sense of nostalgia for a past that seemed simpler and more benign, and a deep sense of loss for what the current and future generations must endure.

“You want to go home,” he said. “But what of the people who live here? When they want to go home, this is where they must go. What do you think of that?”

Related Characters: Mr. Thabane (speaker), Mrs. Curren

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 97

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from a conversation between Mrs. Curren and Mr. Thabane, after Mrs. Curren asks him to take her home and away from Guguletu. Mrs. Curren longs for comfort and familiarity after witnessing the chaos of Guguletu. However, Mr. Thabane wants Mrs. Curren to let the reality of Guguletu sink in because he correctly assumes that she has yet to fully grasp the plight of Black South Africans. His rhetorical question challenges Mrs. Curren to consider the perspective of those whose home is here, a place that Mrs. Curren desperately wants to leave. It contrasts the privilege of having a safe and comfortable home to return to with the reality of those for whom home is a contested, troubled, or undesired place. It draws attention to the disparities between those who can choose where they live and those who cannot, often due to economic hardship or political oppression. (During apartheid, Black South Africans were forced to live in townships like Guguletu outside of Cape Town, so many residents likely didn't have a choice to live here.) Mr. Thabane is asking for empathy and understanding, and he wants Mrs. Curren to admit and understand her privilege in a way she hasn't previously been asked to.

He is a teacher, I thought: that is why he speaks so well. What he is doing to me he has practiced in the classroom. It is the trick one uses to make one's own answer seem to come from the child. Ventriloquism, the legacy of Socrates, as oppressive in Africa as it was in Athens.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Mr. Thabane

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 98

Explanation and Analysis

This is something Mrs. Curren thinks in the middle of her conversation with Mr. Thabane. Mrs. Curren is reflecting on Mr. Thabane's rhetorical skill, as she notices he is able to

guide their conversation in such a way that his desired answer appears to come organically out of her. However, although Mrs. Curren admires his skill—and has used similar tricks herself in her capacity as a former classics professor—she also recognizes it as possibly dubious. She compares his conversational tactic to ventriloquism, suggesting a form of speaking for others or putting words in their mouths.

By invoking Socrates, she refers to the Socratic method, a form of cooperative argumentative dialogue that leads a person to a specific conclusion. Mrs. Curren perceives this method as “oppressive,” implying that it can be used to control or dominate rather than to genuinely educate or enlighten. Mrs. Curren is an educator herself and here she begins to grapple with the consequences of her methods. She wonders whether she has led her students to the answers she wanted to hear rather than the truth.

The inside of the hall was a mess of rubble and charred beams. Against the far wall, shielded from the worst of the rain, were five bodies neatly laid out. The body in the middle was that of Florence's Bheki. He still wore the grey flannel trousers, white shirt and maroon pullover of his school, but his feet were bare. His eyes were open and staring, his mouth open too. The rain had been beating on him for hours, on him and his comrades, not only here but wherever they had been when they met their deaths; their clothes, their very hair, had a flattened, dead look. In the corners of his eyes there were grains of sand. There was sand in his mouth.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Bheki, Florence

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 102

Explanation and Analysis

This is the climax of the scene that takes place in Guguletu, as Mrs. Curren is left to gaze upon Bheki's dead body. Mrs. Curren's entire experience in Guguletu gets increasingly hellish as it drags on, and Bheki's body is the final horror she witnesses. Notably, Bheki is not alone. The presence of four other bodies suggests that what happened to Bheki is far from an isolated incident. Furthermore, Bheki's body is displayed in a ghastly manner, with his mouth wide open and full of sand. In addition to being gruesome, this also recalls two common symbols of death, the skull and the hourglass, suggesting that Bheki's death was inevitable. This

experience makes Mrs. Curren realize the extent of the persecution Black South Africans face under apartheid, while also making her feel helpless to resist the existing regime. Previously, she spoke moral platitudes to Florence and Bheki in the hopes they would incorporate them into their lives and thus live better. However, now she sees just how insignificant and unhelpful her words were, given the horrific everyday reality in Guguletu.

“I tell you the story of this morning mindful that the storyteller, from her office, claims the place of right. It is through my eyes that you see; the voice that speaks in your head is mine. Through me alone do you find yourself here on these desolate flats, smell the smoke in the air, see the bodies of the dead, hear the weeping, shiver in the rain. It is my thoughts that you think, my despair that you feel, and also the first stirrings of welcome for whatever will put an end to thought: sleep, death. To me your sympathies flow; your heart beats with mine.”

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Bheki, Mrs. Curren's Daughter

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 103

Explanation and Analysis

This is a quote from Mrs. Curren as she is reflecting on her experience in Guguletu, while speaking (or writing) directly to her daughter. In particular, she hopes to speak to the power of the storyteller. Mrs. Curren acknowledges the storyteller's control over the reader's experience, emphasizing that it is through her perspective that her daughter (and the reader) engages with the narrative world she creates. It is a passage that brings attention to the act of storytelling itself, making the reader acutely aware of the author's presence and influence over their emotions and reactions. Additionally, there's an implicit reminder that every story is filtered through a particular viewpoint, which shapes the reader's perception. The “desolate flats,” “smoke in the air,” and “bodies of the dead” evoke a visceral, bleak atmosphere, which the reader experiences second-hand, yet vividly due to the author's descriptive prowess. Moreover, the storyteller has the power to evoke empathy in readers, aligning the reader's emotional state with their own. This shows up in the phrase “to me your sympathies flow; your heart beats with mine.” In other words, Mrs. Curren has gotten the reader to share in her emotions and

feel sympathy for Black South Africans. This empathetic connection can be seen as both a form of manipulation and a genuine sharing of experience.

“What did I want? What did the old lady want? What she wanted was to bare something to them, whatever there was that might be bared at this time, in this place. What she wanted, before they got rid of her, was to bring out a scar, a hurt, to force it upon them, to make them see it with their own eyes: a scar, any scar, the scar of all this suffering, but in the end my scar, since our own scars are the only scars we can carry with us.”

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Bheki

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 107

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the end of Mrs. Curren's experience in Guguletu, as she runs up to a police officer and tries to explain her distress. However, words fail her, and she cannot get the officer to understand why she is so agitated. It is a moment that delves into the human need to be seen and understood, particularly through the lens of suffering and pain. Mrs. Curren's desire to “bare something to them” reflects a deep-seated urge to reveal the truth of her experiences. It is a form of seeking validation, to have others acknowledge and possibly empathize with the pain that is so personal yet often remains unshared. Furthermore, the phrase “the scar of all this suffering” suggests a collective pain, implying that Mrs. Curren feels as though she has tapped into the suffering of Black South Africans, but that she does not have the words to express what she feels. As such, the novel seems to suggest that empathy in such situations can only be felt rather than expressed verbally, which make such problems difficult to fix.

☞ Vercueil held out the bottle. A full four inches were gone. I pushed his hand away. "I don't want to drink any more," I said.

"Go on," he said: "get drunk for a change."

"No!" I exclaimed. A tipsy anger flared up in me against his crudity, his indifference. What was I doing here? In the exhausted car the two of us must have looked like nothing so much as belated refugees from the *platteland* of the Great Depression. All we lacked was a coir mattress and a chicken-coop tied on the roof. I snatched the bottle from his hand; but while I was still rolling down the window to throw it out, he wrested it back.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren, Vercueil (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 126

Explanation and Analysis

Following her return from Guguletu, Mrs. Curren starts reevaluating her principles and ideals and wants Vercueil's help with that process. However, the only answer Vercueil can give her is to drown her sorrows in alcohol. Rather than deal with issues that he feels are too complex for any one person to handle, Vercueil endorses surrendering to the numbness that alcohol can provide. However, Mrs. Curren's rejection and anger show her resisting this escape, as she wants to maintain some control or dignity despite her circumstances. The simile comparing them to "belated refugees from the *platteland* of the Great Depression" conjures a vivid image of desolation and poverty. It situates them not only in a physical state of disarray, but also in a historical context associated with hardship and displacement. Mrs. Curren's impulse to throw the bottle away signals a rejection of this comparison. She essentially refuses to succumb to what she perceives as a pitiable state.

☞ And after that, after the dying? Never fear, I will not haunt you. There will be no need to close the windows and seal the chimney to keep the white moth from flapping in during the night and settling on your brow or on the brow of one of the children. The moth is simply what will brush your cheek ever so lightly as you put down the last page of this letter, before it flutters off on its next journey. It is not my soul that will remain with you but the spirit of my soul, the breath, the stirring of the air about these words, the faintest of turbulence traced in the air by the ghostly passage of my pen over the paper your fingers now hold.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Mrs. Curren's Daughter

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 129-130

Explanation and Analysis

After her argument with Vercueil over whether or not to use alcohol to numb her pain, Mrs. Curren directly addresses her daughter to further analyze their relationship and the purpose of her letters. She uses the white moth as a metaphor to convey the transient yet poignant impact she hopes to have on her daughter's life after she passes away. The white moth, traditionally symbolic of the soul or spirit in literature, is described as not a nefarious ghost that Mrs. Curren's daughter is going to have to work hard to keep out of her house, but rather as a delicate, harmless reminder of Mrs. Curren's presence. This imagery evokes a sense of gentleness and impermanence. And this suggests that Mrs. Curren is doing her best, through her letters and her choice to not ask her daughter to come home, to not burden her daughter. Instead, she wants to leave her daughter with understanding as to why Mrs. Curren behaved the way she did. Although Mrs. Curren will elsewhere express some anger toward her daughter because she is no longer in South Africa, this moment sees her at her most idealistic, at least as far as her letters are concerned.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☞ I say I do not want to be put to sleep. The truth is, without sleep I cannot endure. Whatever else it brings, the Diconal at least brings sleep or a simulacrum of sleep. As the pain recedes, as time quickens, as the horizon lifts, my attention, concentrated like a burning-glass on the pain, can slacken for a while; I can draw breath, unclench my hailed hands, straighten my legs.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil, Mrs. Curren's Daughter

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 182

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Mrs. Curren is reflecting on how medication and

sleep are impacting her life. As she says, at this stage, medicine and sleep are the only things keep her alive, and she finds pain relief and being asleep more pleasurable than her waking and lucid existence. However, given that she is continuing to write, at least on occasion, it seems as though she has some time left. Given that Mrs. Curren's cancer is an extended metaphor for the state of South Africa under apartheid, there is a suggestion that apartheid is similarly close to death. However, just as Mrs. Curren's cancer causes her great pain, there is great suffering throughout South Africa because of the violent resistance that has come about due to a history of vicious oppression.

That said, the novel is also an examination of how one woman deals with such pain in near isolation. Just as she promised Vercueil she would, Mrs. Curren has left her daughter in the dark regarding her diagnosis. Everything she describes here she suffers through by herself, though Vercueil and his dog do provide slight and occasional comfort.

☞ I have the story now of how he lost the use of his fingers. It was in an accident at sea. They had to abandon ship. In the scramble his hand was caught in a pulley and crashed. All night he floated on a raft with seven other men and a boy, in agony. The next day they were picked up by a Russian trawler and his hand was given attention. But by then it was too late.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil, Mrs. Curren's Daughter

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 186

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Mrs. Curren tells her daughter that she has finally learned some information about Vercueil's past. Although it does not clear up the mysteries surrounding his character, it does provide some insight into what he was like before arriving in Mrs. Curren's alley. Earlier in the novel, Mrs. Curren accused Vercueil of being lazy and unwilling to work for a living. However, this story confirms that Vercueil was not only willing to work in the past, but he was willing to perform hard and rigorous work. The story of how Vercueil injured his hand is a reminder of the uncontrollable nature of life and the permanent marks that experiences, especially traumatic ones, can leave on people. Vercueil's hand, once a tool and symbol of his capability, is transformed into a constant reminder of the accident and, presumably, a

source of ongoing physical and emotional pain. That Vercueil is finally willing to share something about his past with Mrs. Curren suggests their increasingly intimate relationship.

☞ We share a bed, folded one upon the other like a page folded in two, like two wings folded: old mates, bunkmates, conjoined, conjugal. *Lectus genialis*, *lectus adversus*. His toe-nails, when he takes off his shoes, are yellow, almost brown, like horn. Feet that he keeps out of water for fear of falling: falling into depths where he cannot breathe. A dry creature, a creature of air, like those locust-fairies in Shakespeare with their whipstock of cricket's bone, lash of spider-film. Huge swarms of them borne out to sea on the wind, out of sight of land, tiring, settling one upon another upon another, resolving to drown the Atlantic by their numbers. Swallowed, all of them, to the last. Brittle wings on the sea-floor sighing like a forest of leaves; dead eyes by the million; and the crabs moving among them, clutching, grinding.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 189

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Mrs. Curren describes how she and Vercueil sleep in bed together during the final weeks of her life. The description of two people sharing a bed, "folded one upon the other," suggests a closeness that is both physical and perhaps emotional, despite Vercueil's desire to keep an emotional distance from Mrs. Curren for the majority of the novel. The Latin phrases "*lectus genialis*" and "*lectus adversus*" refer to the marriage bed and the bed of adversity, respectively, which implies that their shared life encompasses both comfort and suffering. Even though Vercueil experiences a degree of comfort in Mrs. Curren's bed, the comparison of his toenails to horns and the description of his aversion to water evoke the image of a creature (and not necessarily a person) not entirely at home in its current environment. Additionally, the final image of the sea-floor littered with brittle wings and dead eyes, over which crabs scavenge, serves as a stark reminder of mortality. It paints a gruesome scene of what happens after death, where what was once alive and animated becomes still and is reclaimed by the elements.

☞☞ "Is it time?" I said.

I got back into bed, into the tunnel between the cold sheets. The curtains parted; he came in beside me. For the first time I smelled nothing. He took me in his arms and held me with mighty force, so that the breath went out of me in a rush. From that embrace there was no warmth to be had.

Related Characters: Mrs. Curren (speaker), Vercueil

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 198

Explanation and Analysis

These are the words that end the novel, as Vercueil gets into bed with Mrs. Curren, perhaps for the final time. The

scene is both intensely intimate and distant, as Vercueil enters Mrs. Curren's bed and embraces her while lacking any warmth. The physicality of the embrace, described with such intensity that "the breath went out of [Mrs. Curren] in a rush," conveys a sense of overwhelming force, but the lack of warmth in that embrace is striking. It suggests a feeling of emptiness or the absence of genuine affection or comfort that one would normally seek in such close physical contact. Perhaps this is because Vercueil knows he is about to end Mrs. Curren's life and has deliberately distanced himself emotionally from her so that he is capable of performing the task.

Presumably, Mrs. Curren lived at least one more day so that she could finish her letters to her daughter. However, because the novel (and therefore the letters) is done, there is an implication that Mrs. Curren dies shortly after writing its final words.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

Mrs. Curren writes to someone who she calls “you” about what is going on in her life. She writes that she found a homeless man lying outside of her home, in an alley where “you” used to play. The man is asleep and smells like a mixture of alcohol and urine. Mrs. Curren had just returned from her appointment with Dr. Syfret, who diagnosed her with terminal **cancer**. When she comes upon the homeless man, she is trembling. She warns him that he cannot stay outside her home. For a moment, the man does not move or even seem to register what she says. However, he eventually gets up and walks away without saying a word.

Mrs. Curren steps into her home and thinks about her diagnosis. She tells “you” about how she longs for you—her daughter—and how she wishes you were still there with her. She wants to give her daughter a hug and feel as though she will live on in her daughter once her physical form is gone. However, because her daughter is not there, she plans to face her death alone and record her experience in a series of the letters (which make up the content of the book).

Mrs. Curren spends the afternoon doing chores to keep her mind off her diagnosis. In the evening, she goes outside and finds that the homeless man has returned. This time, he has a dog with him—a young collie. Mrs. Curren warns the man that she does not want a mess on her hands and then offers him something to eat. Without saying anything, the man follows Mrs. Curren inside. Mrs. Curren gives him a sandwich, which she thinks he gave to the dog when she was not looking.

Mrs. Curren, who is writing during apartheid in South Africa, reflects on the current state of Cape Town, where she lives. It has many homeless people and gangs. She does not fear the homeless people because they are harmless in her experience, but the gangs frighten her. The homeless population largely consists of Black people, who are unduly discriminated against because of apartheid.

Age of Iron is composed of a series of letters from Mrs. Curren to her daughter. Because she addresses her daughter as “you,” it is as if she is talking directly to the reader. This quality gives the entire novel a feeling of intimacy, while also adding to its political efficacy, as Coetzee wants to make his reader feel as though they have a stake in the concerns of South Africa, which was at this time under its apartheid regime (which upheld racial segregation).



Here, the novel starts developing a relationship between suffering and loneliness. As Mrs. Curren implies, physical suffering becomes much worse when one has to go through it alone. Additionally, this passage hints at one of the novel's large questions; that is, what is the purpose of writing and recording one's experiences?



Mrs. Curren has some compassion for the man, though she clearly desires to keep him at a distance. Meanwhile, the man himself is an enigma, as he remains silent under questioning; despite his rugged appearance, he does not seem to be hungry, assuming Mrs. Curren is correct about what happened to the sandwich.



Apartheid refers to the legally enforced system of racial segregation and discrimination that was in place in South Africa from 1948 until the early 1990s. This policy categorized the population into different racial groups, granting considerable political and social privileges to white South Africans. Conversely, non-white South Africans, particularly Black people, faced intense racial discrimination, economic disparities, and a lack of political representation.



The following morning, Mrs. Curren brings the homeless man coffee and finds him urinating in the alleyway. She offers him work if he would like it. The man does not respond; he merely sips his coffee. Mrs. Curren starts to lecture him about how he is wasting his life. However, he still does not respond. When he is done with his coffee, he hands Mrs. Curren her mug, spits at her feet, and then walks away. That night, the man does not sleep in the alley near Mrs. Curren's home. However, she sees some of his possessions nearby, so she knows he means to return. The next day, the homeless man comes back. Mrs. Curren senses him looking into her window, as she is watching television. However, she doesn't turn around and acknowledge his presence. Instead, she turns up the sound on the television so he can hear it.

Later, Mrs. Curren leaves to go shopping when suddenly, she collapses in pain. The homeless man hears her cry out and helps her inside her home. She invites him to sit down and then tells him about her **cancer**. Rather than address what she says, the man replies, "This is a big house, [...] You could turn it into a boarding-house." Mrs. Curren is uninterested in the suggestion. She explains that her housekeeper, Florence, usually stays in one of the rooms. However, she is out of town at the moment.

Mrs. Curren also tells the homeless man about her husband, who is now dead; and her daughter, who left for America in 1976. Her daughter is the same person who she is writing to—her only child. Mrs. Curren asks the man about his disability, as he previously mentioned receiving a disability pension. The man holds up his hand to show Mrs. Curren that three of his fingers crookedly curl in toward his palm. He explains that he cannot move them. Mrs. Curren asks the man if an accident caused the issue. The man nods but does not explain further. Then, Mrs. Curren tells the homeless man she will pay him if he agrees to cut her lawn. The man goes outside and starts the task but does not finish it. Mrs. Curren pays him for an hour's worth of work, and then he leaves.

On his way out of Mrs. Curren's home, the homeless man knocks over the litter box she keeps for her cats. He does not clean up the mess. Mrs. Curren thinks about how temperamental her cats can be, especially when it comes to feeding time. Then, she takes her pain medication and quickly falls asleep. In the middle of the night, she wakes up and hears the homeless man rifling through her things. In particular, she hears him take some money from her desk.

Mrs. Curren wants to help the homeless man but does not know how to help him if he will not help himself. Her frustration leads to condescension, which he does not take well to. Despite their differences, there are similarities between the homeless man and Mrs. Curren. Both are lonely people who are suffering in silence, and both of them are struggling to find ways to connect with each other.



Although the homeless man's demeanor is often callous, he does what he can to help Mrs. Curren when he sees she is in trouble. However, when Mrs. Curren tries to have a conversation with him about her troubles, he can only think of things to say that directly interest him—such as perhaps finding a place to live in Mrs. Curren's boarding-house. As such, they talk past each other rather than to each other.



Mrs. Curren is eager to open up to the homeless man and share her life story with him. However, he has no desire to reciprocate. Still, a relationship starts to form between them. Rather than reject the work Mrs. Curren offered him as he did in the past, the homeless man decides to take her up on it. However, he performs the task she gives him on his own terms and does not complete it. Presumably, Mrs. Curren does not appreciate that he did not finish the job, even though she decides to pay him anyway.



The cats are Mrs. Curren's only companions other than the homeless man because her housekeeper Florence is away. When he leaves, she has no more human contact. The knocked over litter box is a reminder that the cats get to live and defecate inside, while the homeless man must sleep outside and use the alley as a bathroom, highlighting the unfairness of the situation.



Feeling ill, Mrs. Curren spends the following day in bed. She feels too sick to eat or do anything, so she reads Tolstoy. The following day, she tries to get her car started but she cannot, so she asks the homeless man to help her. The homeless man pushes the car down the driveway, while Mrs. Curren tries to get the engine to turn over. Their plan works, so Mrs. Curren asks the man if he would like to go to Fish Hoek with her. The man gets into the car and brings his collie with him.

Mrs. Curren stops the car at a scenic spot overlooking False Bay. She asks the homeless man if he is from the Cape. The man responds that he is but is willing to share little else about himself. Realizing she won't get anything out of him, Mrs. Curren begins looking at the natural world around her. Moments later, she breaks down into tears and then starts wailing. When Mrs. Curren pulls herself together, she starts to apologize to the man, only to realize he is barely paying attention to her.

Mrs. Curren has a hard time getting the car into gear, so the homeless man helps guide her through the process. She narrowly avoids an accident while pulling away from the outlook, which causes the man to shout at her. Eventually, they make it home in one piece.

Later in the day, Mrs. Curren asks the homeless man to prune her garden. He tells her he does not know how. Mrs. Curren suspects he knows what to do but does not want to do it. Instead, she gives him other yard work to do. She promises to pay him, as long as he continues to help her out. However, she also warns him that she will not be giving him any more charity if he does not.

For once, the homeless man shows he is listening to what Mrs. Curren is saying. He asks her why he would not deserve money if he did not work. Then, he questions whether anyone really deserves anything. Irritated, Mrs. Curren shoves her purse at him and says, "What do you believe in, then? Taking? Taking what you want? Go on: take!" The man does exactly as Mrs. Curren suggests. He opens her purse, takes some money out, and then leaves. A half hour later, he returns with fresh bottles of alcohol. While the homeless man lays outside on a found mattress and drinks, Mrs. Curren begins playing piano. Realizing that the man is probably listening to her, Mrs. Curren plays Bach to the best of her ability.

Again, although the homeless man does not offer Mrs. Curren emotional warmth, he is willing to help meet her basic needs. He knows she will not get the car started by herself, so he helps. He is also willing to travel around with Mrs. Curren, although his willingness to do so seems based more in indifference than anything else.



Mrs. Curren desperately wants to emotionally connect with the homeless man, but he is unwilling to share anything about himself. Mrs. Curren feels guilty about appearing emotionally vulnerable around a person who appears so emotionally stunted. She feels like she is placing a burden on him that he would never place on her.



At her age and in her condition, Mrs. Curren has a hard time doing anything by herself. Even the homeless man seems more knowledgeable about cars than her, despite not having one himself.



Mrs. Curren wants to help the homeless man, but only on her terms. She makes it clear that their relationship is hierarchical, and she decides whether he gets paid. More than anything, Mrs. Curren does not want to feel like she is being taken advantage of.



Mrs. Curren has never had someone like the homeless man question her. When she hands him her purse, she assumes he will back down and agree that it is wrong to take money from someone without working for it. However, instead, the man does exactly as Mrs. Curren asks and then uses her money to buy himself alcohol. Although flabbergasted in the moment, Mrs. Curren shows a begrudging respect for the man and shows that she still cares about him by playing Bach.



The next day, one of Mrs. Curren's neighbors calls her and warns her that she has seen a "vagrant" hanging around her house. Mrs. Curren explains that the homeless man is actually not a vagrant at all because he works for her. After hanging up the phone, Mrs. Curren decides she does not plan to answer it anymore. She has no desire to speak with anyone except her daughter and God.

Mrs. Curren contemplates her death and the state of her house. She worries that her house is a big mess that someone is going to have to deal with once she is dead. Rather than fixate on her death, Mrs. Curren thinks about her youth instead, when she was happy and carefree. In her view, South Africa was a much better place during that time. Now, it has turned into a violent and dangerous place. Three years ago, someone broke into Mrs. Curren's home and robbed her. To prevent future incident, Mrs. Curren had metal bars put on her windows. She values the safety they provide, even though they make her feel like a caged animal.

Mrs. Curren falls asleep and wakes up a few hours later. She makes herself tea and then puts on a record. Outside, she sees the homeless man smoking in the alley, and she realizes he is listening to the music along with her. Mrs. Curren thinks about how her relationship with this man is strangely intimate. She wonders what it would be like to have sex with him, and if their souls are somehow intertwined.

Sometime later—it is not clear how long—Mrs. Curren shows the homeless man pictures of her daughter and grandchildren. Then, she asks the man if he will send some private papers (the letters that compose the novel) to her daughter once she is dead. In response, the man says he is unsure if he is the right person for the job. He suggests getting someone else instead. However, Mrs. Curren insists that she would like him to do it. Eventually, he gives in and promises her he will complete the task.

CHAPTER 2

Florence, Mrs. Curren's housekeeper, returns to Mrs. Curren's residence with her two young daughters and her teenage son, Bheki. This is the first time Bheki has come with Florence, and Mrs. Curren asks if he will be staying for an extended period of time. Florence explains that her sister cannot look after Bheki anymore because it has become too dangerous in Guguletu, the nearby township where Florence's sister lives.

Here, Mrs. Curren becomes defensive on the homeless man's behalf. Although she has her own reservations about the homeless man, she dislikes how disrespectfully her neighbor speaks about him. Notably, the novel never mentions the homeless man's race, so it is unclear if racial animus motivated the neighbor's call.



Apartheid began in 1948, most likely when Mrs. Curren was a teenager or a young adult. While race was certainly an issue in pre-1948 South Africa, a white child like Mrs. Curren would never have had to worry about it. Although there were violent struggles throughout the apartheid period, the late 1880s and early 1990s—when the novel takes place—were certainly the most violent, as Black South Africans began to openly rebel against their oppressive government.



Although Mrs. Curren hypothesizes what it would be like to be intensely intimate with this man, there is still a larger distance between them than she seems to want to realize. Although they are listening to music and watching television together, the wall between them says everything about their differing experiences of the world.



Again, the homeless man does not jump on the opportunity to help Mrs. Curren with anything personal; he would prefer to keep himself at a distance. Similarly, Mrs. Curren wants to keep a certain distance from her daughter. She wants her daughter to know about the end of her life, but only after she is dead.



Guguletu—which is more commonly spelled Gugulethu—is a township just outside of Cape Town. During apartheid, Black South Africans were not allowed to live in Cape Town and had to live in its surrounding townships, such as Guguletu. In the late 1980s and early 1990s, there was widespread civil unrest in Guguletu, to which this passage alludes.



Because Florence has a lot going on, Mrs. Curren promises to help with the housework. However, she quickly falls behind and Florence has to do most of the work anyway. Mrs. Curren thinks about how much Bheki has grown since she first met him. She asks Florence about why he is not in school. Florence explains that the schools in Guguletu have all closed down.

Florence asks Mrs. Curren about the homeless man living outside her house. Mrs. Curren introduces him as Mr. Vercueil and says he is staying with them for the time being. She promises Florence that Vercueil will not be any trouble. However, Florence is not so sure. That afternoon, Vercueil works on the lawnmower while Hope and Beauty, Florence's daughters, play nearby. Beauty repeatedly walks up to Vercueil to try and engage him, but each time he shoos her away. Eventually, Vercueil gives in and plays with Beauty by taking her hands and spinning her around. Excited, Hope runs over to Vercueil, and he spins her too. However, Florence sees what is going on and takes the girls away from Vercueil, who promptly returns to working on the lawnmower.

Mrs. Curren asks Florence more about what is going on with the children in Guguletu since they are no longer in school. Florence explains that many of the children and teenagers behave wildly because they are not in school and have no mothers or fathers to look after them. That evening, Mrs. Curren lays in bed and thinks about how much she envies Florence's life. Florence is still healthy and has her children by her side, while Mrs. Curren is lonely and dying.

Mrs. Curren recalls a time from the previous year when she drove Florence to meet William, Florence's husband. William's job was to slaughter chickens. Mrs. Curren recalls watching William pounce on a chicken and tie a wire around its feet before sending it down an assembly line to another man, who promptly decapitated it. Mrs. Curren was not prepared for what she saw, and she wonders about the effects such a job would have on someone's psyche. The chickens remind Mrs. Curren of how killing and dying can be easy and sudden.

Mrs. Curren is blind to some aspects of the Black South African experience—for instance, she did not know that the schools in Guguletu had closed. This highlights her narrow view and her privilege, as she clearly doesn't have to know all about the unrest, while Florence and other Black South Africans have no choice.



Here, the homeless man finally gets a name, and it is notably peculiar. This strange name creates a sense of racial ambiguity, and it marks Vercueil as an outsider. Meanwhile, Hope and Beauty's names represent hope for South Africa's future. Unlike the other characters in the novel, Florence's daughters are full of hope and beauty; they engage the world around them without any anxiety about their race.



The fact that Mrs. Curren envies Florence demonstrates how out of touch she is with Florence's everyday reality. Mrs. Curren only sees the positive parts of Florence's existence. She has not seen Guguletu, nor does she have a sense of the anxiety Florence has about her children's future.



This is the one and only time that William comes up in the novel. It is unclear whether or not he plays an active part in his children's lives or if he and Florence are still married. Regardless, it is an important memory, as Mrs. Curren gets some insight into what life is like for a lower-class Black South African, who holds a job that she has difficulty comprehending.



In a new letter to her daughter, Mrs. Curren writes about how Vercueil spends all the money he gets from her on booze. He drank plenty before she began giving him money, and now he takes advantage of the fact that he has money to get drunk all the time. Meanwhile, Bheki has begun bringing one of his friends from school around Mrs. Curren's residence. One day, Vercueil asks Bheki's friend to get him some water. Instead, Bheki's friend grabs one of Vercueil's bottles of alcohol and dumps it on him. The incident enrages Vercueil. However, Bheki's friend continues to mock him, proclaiming, "They are making you into a dog! [...] 'Do you want to be a dog?'" Mrs. Curren witnesses the incident and immediately dislikes Bheki's friend.

The incident ends with Vercueil and Bheki's friend hitting each other. Mrs. Curren sees what is going on and goes to complain to Florence. She asks Florence about Bheki's friend and says she does not want him hanging around. Florence simply shrugs; she does not care about Vercueil and does not want him around. Mrs. Curren refers to the alley as Vercueil's home and says the boys should not mistreat him.

In response, Florence calls Vercueil a "rubbish person" and suggests that Mrs. Curren get rid of him. Mrs. Curren says that no one is a "rubbish person," and Vercueil will not be going anywhere because he is her "messenger." Her comments cause Florence to raise an eyebrow; she does not understand why Mrs. Curren has such a soft spot for Vercueil.

Vercueil leaves his spot in the alley for some time, which causes Mrs. Curren to argue further with Florence about what occurred. She tells Florence that she should set a better example for the boys and not allow them to treat Vercueil so barbarically. Mrs. Curren is particularly annoyed because the boys have no respect for their elders. Florence responds that the boys do not misbehave because of how they were raised. Rather, they are cruel because they were raised in a cruel world created and governed by white people who treat them poorly.

The conversation causes Mrs. Curren to reflect upon how intolerably cruel South Africa has become. She refers to the present as "the age of iron" because of how hard everyone has become. She is happy that her daughter left South Africa when she did, even though she misses her dearly.

Although Vercueil gives little insight into his past, he seems to be running from something. He drinks every chance he gets and appears closed off whenever Mrs. Curren tries to discuss his existence previous to arriving on her doorstep. Meanwhile, the incident with Bheki's friend showcases the cruelty that Mrs. Curren feels has become all too common in South Africa. It is unclear whether Bheki's friend acts out toward Vercueil because he is Black, homeless, or both (and as the novel never reveals Vercueil's race, readers can never know for sure).



Again, because Vercueil's race is ambiguous, it is hard to know why Florence and her family dislike him. Still, Mrs. Curren takes an admirable, if perhaps naive, view that it's still not okay for the boys to torment him, showing her compassion and also her incomplete understanding of why the boys target him.



In the same way it is unclear why Florence and her family dislike Vercueil, it is equally unclear why Mrs. Curren is so eager to defend him. Would she treat Vercueil the same regardless of his race? As his race remains unstated, though, readers are simply left to wonder.



Here, Mrs. Curren wants to have an argument about the treatment of individuals by other individuals, while Florence wants to discuss how society shapes groups of people and causes them to act in certain ways. The novel does not suggest that there is a clear winner in this debate. However, it is clear that neither Florence nor Mrs. Curren understands where the other is coming from.



The novel's title plays off of "The Iron Age," the time in human history from 1200-550 BCE when iron-based technologies became common. Here, the name becomes a metaphor for the idea that everyone in South Africa has to harden themselves to the outside world as a protective measure.



One day—it is not clear how much time has passed—Mrs. Curren wakes up and hears Florence fighting with someone, though she cannot make out who. When she asks Florence about the incident, Florence refuses to say who she was talking to. Mrs. Curren asks if Bheki's friend stayed in the house last night. Florence admits that Bheki and his friend both slept in Mrs. Curren's garage. Mrs. Curren chastises Florence because no one asked her permission.

While looking around her property, Mrs. Curren notices that a police car has been parked out front and seems to be keeping an eye on her place. The police spot Mrs. Curren and come up to her. They ask her about Bheki and his friend, and whether or not she gave them permission to be on her property. Mrs. Curren assures the policemen that the boys are allowed to be there.

When Mrs. Curren returns inside, she tells Florence to get rid of Bheki's friend because he has brought police surveillance to her house. She worries his presence and behavior will get Bheki in trouble with the law. Florence understands Mrs. Curren's concerns but says she won't send Bheki's friend back to Guguletu because of the persistent violence. Mrs. Curren gives up and runs herself a bath. While bathing, she calls out to her dead mother, desperately in need of her mother's support.

One morning, Mrs. Curren looks outside her window and sees that Vercueil is back. It is raining hard outside, so she asks Vercueil if he would like to come in. Vercueil steps inside and a woman who Mrs. Curren does not recognize steps in behind him. Mrs. Curren is annoyed that Vercueil did not mention he had a companion and asks who she is. Neither Vercueil nor the woman answer her question.

Angrily, Mrs. Curren tells them that they are allowed to stay until the rain stops, but then she wants them out. Vercueil falls asleep on Mrs. Curren's couch, making sounds that remind Mrs. Curren of her daughter. When Mrs. Curren wakes up the following morning, both Vercueil and the mysterious woman are still in her house.

Determined to take control of her house, Mrs. Curren begins working on the issue of Bheki's friend, who is still staying on her property. She tells Bheki that she does not want him and his friend sleeping in her car. Bheki does not say anything in response. Bheki's silence is the final straw for Mrs. Curren. She is angry that everyone else is using her property like it belongs to them without showing her any respect or appreciation. It makes her feel like she is dead before she has actually died.

Similar to Vercueil, Florence and her family tend to take advantage of Mrs. Curren's hospitality. Mrs. Curren views Florence's behavior as a breach of trust, while Florence thinks she is simply trying to help a young man survive in a world that is actively hostile to his existence.



Based on what the police say, they have not seen Bheki or his friend do anything wrong; rather, they see Black South Africans in a place where white South Africans live and assume there must be a problem. It seems likely that they hope Mrs. Curren will give them an excuse to make trouble for Bheki and his friend.



Mrs. Curren does not realize that the police are profiling Florence and her family. Rather, she assumes that Bheki's friend is the problem, an assumption that arises from her own mistrust. However, despite Mrs. Curren's strong feelings, she is not biased enough against Bheki's friend to send him back to Guguletu, where he would surely be in danger.



Again, Mrs. Curren takes pity on Vercueil and again he immediately pushes up against the limits of her hospitality. As always, Vercueil refuses to explain his behavior; he acts as he wishes and allows Mrs. Curren to interpret his actions as she will.



Mrs. Curren tries to set a boundary for herself but fails. At the end of the day, she is a frail and dying woman; if Vercueil and his female companion want to stay inside, there is little she can do to stop them outside of calling the police.



Mrs. Curren desperately wants to feel as if she is in control of some aspects of her life. She does not like that others give her the silent treatment rather than responding to her concerns because it makes her feel as though they are simply using her for her material wealth. However, her suspicions may be correct as far as Bheki and his friend are concerned.



Mrs. Curren finds Florence and asks her to get rid of Vercueil's female friend. Florence finds the woman lying down on a bed of cushions, asleep and unresponsive. Florence grabs the woman by the arm, gets her to stand up, and takes her outside of the house. As this is going on, Mrs. Curren sees Vercueil and warns him that he has gone too far this time.

In the meantime, Bheki and his friend ride together on a bicycle, with Bheki sitting on the handlebars. Mrs. Curren sees that the police from the other day are chasing after them. Bheki's friend pedals as fast as he can to get away, but the police van quickly catches up to them. The police swing their door open and knock the teenagers off the bike. Mrs. Curren witnesses the entire incident and begins calling for people to come help. A crowd forms around the boys as Mrs. Curren does her best to tend to them. She sees that the boys are hurt and promises them that the ambulance will arrive soon. She also tells everyone that the police hurt the boys intentionally.

Florence arrives on the scene and tells Mrs. Curren that she does not want the help of an ambulance. However, Bheki's friend is in a rough state. He has a bad cut on his forehead and is bleeding a lot. One of the nearby men tries to stop the bleeding, but Bheki's friend still loses a significant amount of blood. Mrs. Curren steps in to try and stop Bheki's friend from losing blood, and though she is partially successful, she knows that professional medical help is required. Eventually, an ambulance arrives and takes Bheki's friend away.

Once Bheki's friend has left with the ambulance, Mrs. Curren goes looking for Florence. When she finds Florence, she chastises her for fleeing the scene. Florence explains that she wanted to avoid the police. Mrs. Curren says that she plans to file a formal complaint of police misconduct. She knows the police acted maliciously and wants to see justice served. However, Florence warns her to leave the issue alone because she thinks involving the police will only make matters worse.

Later the same day, Bheki's friend's grandmother calls Mrs. Curren's house asking about her grandson. She says that she could not find any record of him arriving at the hospital. Mrs. Curren calls around and also cannot find any official sign that Bheki's friend arrived where he was supposed to. Mrs. Curren, along with Florence, Vercueil, and Bheki, get in the car and head to the nearest hospital.

Mrs. Curren makes Florence do what she cannot, physically and emotionally. Unlike Mrs. Curren, Florence has no issue with getting rid of Vercueil and his friend. Even though Mrs. Curren warns Vercueil here, it seems unlikely that this threat has any teeth—she's shown little appetite for punishing Vercueil thus far.



As far as Mrs. Curren can see, Bheki and his friend are not doing anything wrong. The police pursue and attack them out of nowhere without any care for their safety. Mrs. Curren views the incident as a great injustice and does everything she can to make sure others know the truth of what happened. It is an eye-opening moment for her character that will become even more significant as the plot progresses.



Florence's reluctance to call an ambulance and her fear of the police underscore the deep mistrust between the Black South African community and state institutions. In her eyes, such institutions are oppressive rather than protective, and she thinks she will only make Bheki's situation worse if she contacts them. However, as Mrs. Curren points out, her unwillingness to act could cost Bheki his life.



Mrs. Curren's attempt to seek justice through a formal complaint highlights the clash between moral righteousness and practical wisdom in a society divided by racial injustice. Her actions show a commitment to principles of justice and humanity, but Florence's response suggests a pragmatic understanding of the futility and potential danger of confronting an abusive system.



The situation with the receptionist at the hospital, where there is no record of Bheki's friend, points to systemic issues of negligence and the invisibility of Black South Africans in society. The bureaucratic indifference is exactly what Florence expected, but it blindsides Mrs. Curren.



Mrs. Curren questions a receptionist, who insists there is no record of Bheki's friend at the hospital. The receptionist suggests that she go to Groote Schuur, a different hospital. The group heads to Groote Schuur as the receptionist suggests. When they arrive, Mrs. Curren sends Bheki and Florence inside to look for Bheki's friend because she is in too much pain.

Mrs. Curren's physical pain, which prevents her from accompanying Bheki and Florence inside the hospital, is emblematic of her limited ability to help those around her. After all, how can she help tackle the systemic injustices of South African society when she can barely walk?



While sitting in the car with Vercueil, Mrs. Curren thinks about the state of her **cancer** and the current condition of South Africa. She wonders whether it would be better to give herself over to the nurses at a hospital like Groote Schuur, so she no longer has to worry about caring for herself. After thinking about her illness for a while, Mrs. Curren tells Vercueil that she has not informed her daughter that she is about to die. Her daughter knows she is sick but thinks she will soon be better.

Mrs. Curren's contemplation of her illness in parallel with the state of South Africa serves as a metaphor for the nation's suffering under apartheid. Her cancer is not just a physical ailment; it also symbolizes the moral decay and the pain of living in a deeply flawed society. Her consideration of surrendering to the care of nurses reflects a desire for relinquishment of personal responsibility amid overwhelming societal turmoil.



Vercueil advises Mrs. Curren to tell her daughter the truth and ask her to return to South Africa. Mrs. Curren explains that her daughter left South Africa on principle and will not return until the social conditions improve. Moments later, Florence and Bheki return. They tell Mrs. Curren that they found Bheki's friend in a room with several old people who are close to death. Florence is upset that they would do such a thing to a young boy.

The conversation between Mrs. Curren and Vercueil about her daughter encapsulates the generational and ideological divides that apartheid inflicted on families. Mrs. Curren's reluctance to tell her daughter about her impending death mirrors the larger denial and lack of communication between different groups in South Africa about the reality of the country's injustices. On a personal level, she also does not want to burden her daughter with her death. However, as Vercueil tells her, she will be burdening her daughter one way or the other regardless of when she finds out.



The following day, Mrs. Curren and Vercueil go back to the hospital so Mrs. Curren can check on Bheki's friend. Bheki's friend does not like that Mrs. Curren has come to see him and jerks his hand away when Mrs. Curren touches it. Mrs. Curren asks him to give her a chance. Then, she tells Bheki's friend—as well as Vercueil, who is standing nearby—that she was once a classics professor at a South African university. Then, she briefly discusses Thucydides' writings on war and the hypocrisy of people who make rules but do not follow them.

Mrs. Curren's attempt to connect with Bheki's friend through her knowledge of classical literature and the hypocrisy highlighted in Thucydides' writings on war speaks to the universal experiences of conflict and the failure of those in power to abide by their own rules. However, it also demonstrates how far away her worldview is from that of Bheki's friend, who has presumably never heard of Thucydides and who seems not to care what Mrs. Curren has to say.



After the visit, Mrs. Curren and Vercueil return home. There, they watch television together and page through one of Mrs. Curren's old books. Vercueil starts to open up to Mrs. Curren, telling her that he was once a sailor. That night, Mrs. Curren suggests that Vercueil sleep inside. She also asks him to move in permanently to help take care of her in exchange for a roof over his head.

Vercueil's background as a sailor and his gradual opening up to Mrs. Curren signify the breaking down of personal barriers and the potential for human connection despite societal divisions. Mrs. Curren offering him a place to stay in exchange for his care creates a microcosm of mutual dependency and deepens their relationship.



Mrs. Curren also spends some time talking to local law enforcement to try and get justice for Bheki's friend. However, she does not get very far. The authorities tell her that she cannot file a complaint unless she was the one affected by the incident. Frustrated, Mrs. Curren hangs up the phone and expresses her anger to Vercueil. Vercueil barely registers Mrs. Curren's mood. Rather than respond to her complaints, he asks her if he can have some money.

Mrs. Curren's frustration with the authorities' refusal to allow her to file a complaint on behalf of Bheki's friend illustrates the institutional racism and the futility of seeking justice within an oppressive system. Meanwhile, Vercueil's response highlights his indifference to larger social issues, which may or may not affect him in the future.



CHAPTER 3

One night, Mrs. Curren wakes up to a telephone call from a woman who breathlessly demands to speak with Florence. Mrs. Curren is unsure of exactly what is wrong, but Bheki seems to be involved. Mrs. Curren offers to take Florence to Guguletu to search for her son. She wakes up Vercueil and explains the situation, urging him to join. However, Vercueil has no interest in getting up to look for Bheki, so she is left on her own to guide Florence.

Vercueil's refusal to help search for Bheki underscores a sense of apathy or perhaps helplessness that pervades the novel. His character often acts as a foil to Mrs. Curren, representing a withdrawal from the struggles around them. In contrast, Mrs. Curren's decision to help Florence, despite her fear, reflects a moral imperative that pushes her beyond her comfort zone.



Mrs. Curren wants to help Florence but is scared of what she will find in Guguletu. She knows the violence has only gotten worse in recent days. Mrs. Curren, Florence, and Florence's other children get into the car and head toward Guguletu. On the way there, the police pull over Mrs. Curren and ask her to state her business. Mrs. Curren lies and says she is just taking Florence and her kids home. The lie works and the policemen let them continue on their way.

The encounter with the police during their drive to Guguletu represents the ever-present threat of state authority and the need for subterfuge and lies to navigate the oppressive social landscape. Mrs. Curren's lie to the police to protect Florence and her children is a small act of rebellion against the authorities.



When they arrive in Guguletu, Florence takes Mrs. Curren, Hope, and Beauty inside a house. There, she introduces Mrs. Curren to one of her cousins, Mr. Thabane, who will act as their escort. They leave Hope and Beauty behind to go looking for Bheki. Mr. Thabane says he is not sure exactly where Bheki has gone. He also warns them that the place they are going is essentially a warzone and will be quite dangerous.

The description of Guguletu as a warzone, with its burning buildings and the hopeless demeanor of its inhabitants, paints a stark picture of the physical and psychological devastation wrought by apartheid.



After a quick car ride, Mr. Thabane, Florence, and Mrs. Curren get out of the car and slowly make their way through a muddy street. There is chaos all around them, as the ground is littered with trash and buildings burn in the distance. Everyone Mrs. Curren sees looks beaten down and hopeless. Mrs. Curren and her companions come upon a scene where a woman is going in and out of a burning house to save her belongings. However, some men stop her—presumably the same men who set the house on fire—after her second trip. The scene turns into an all-out brawl between the perpetrators and an angry mob that has gathered around to witness the chaos. A stampede ensues, and Mrs. Curren struggles to get away.

The woman attempting to save her belongings from a burning house highlights the futility many felt in attempting to oppose the white South African regime that was determined to keep Black South Africans under their control. However, the angry mob outside the woman's home demonstrates that if a regime is oppressive enough, it will eventually face a violent resistance, which has the potential to harm the guilty and the innocent alike. Everything Mrs. Curren is witnessing is far worse than anything she ever could have imagined from the safety of her home.



Mrs. Curren falls to the ground and hears gunshots in the distance. She has lost all sense of where she is and feels overwhelmingly hopeless. Mr. Thabane sees her in the mud and helps her to her feet. Then, he asks her to follow him. Mrs. Curren does as he asks, and they make the way back to her car. There, she sees a young man trying to start her car and orders him to step away from it. Mr. Thabane tells Mrs. Curren that the man is one of Bheki's friends. However, Mrs. Curren no longer cares about finding Bheki; she just wants to leave Guguletu.

Rather than take Mrs. Curren to her car, Mr. Thabane argues with her. He tells her to think of all the people who call Guguletu home and have to live in it day in and day out. Mrs. Curren agrees that the circumstances are terrible, but she's not sure what she is supposed to do about it. She tries to find the words to describe how horrible it is, but she does not know what to say. Mr. Thabane suggests that her inability to articulate the horrors of the situation is a moral failure on her part.

Mr. Thabane takes Mrs. Curren back to Florence, and Mrs. Curren asks Florence if she has located Bheki. Florence nods her head without saying a word and then steps away from Mrs. Curren. A small crowd has assembled nearby, and Mr. Thabane works his way to the front of it to see what they are staring at. A minute later, he grabs Mrs. Curren and tells her to come look. Mrs. Curren sees a group of bodies leaning up against a wall, one of which is Bheki, his eyes and mouth still open in a permanent look of horror.

Shaken, Mrs. Curren returns to her vehicle to find someone has smashed her windshield with a rock. She tries to get the image of the bodies out of her mind but cannot. Nearby, she encounters a police officer, with whom she briefly discusses the situation. The officer tells her that the situation is more complex than she may realize, and it is unclear who is responsible. After her conversation with the officer, Mrs. Curren goes home, permanently changed by the day's events.

Mrs. Curren sleeps through the entire next day. When she finally wakes up, she is an emotional wreck. She does not know what has become of her life or South Africa. She thinks about her childhood and how much things have changed for the worse. Cold, tired, and lonely, Mrs. Curren asks Vercueil to come join her in bed. However, Vercueil ignores her and stays where he is.

Mrs. Curren's fall and the sensation of hopelessness that overwhelms her as she hears gunshots represent a moment of profound despair. This moment is not only about the physical danger, but also about recognizing of the deep moral crisis that has engulfed the country. However, the situation is so shocking that Mrs. Curren immediately abandons her mission in favor of self-preservation.



Mr. Thabane's confrontation with Mrs. Curren forces her to consider her moral responsibility. He implies that her inability to articulate the horrors of apartheid is not just a failure of words but is a failure of moral understanding and empathy. This interaction suggests that those not directly affected by the violence, like Mrs. Curren, are still implicated in it through their inability to fully grasp its impact.



The discovery of Bheki's body and Mrs. Curren's reaction—her shock and the haunting image that lingers in her mind—represent a violent rupture in her perception of the world. Witnessing this brutality forces her to confront the reality of the violence from which she has been insulated, and it acts as a catalyst for a deep existential crisis.



The smashed windshield serves as a metaphor for the shattered illusions Mrs. Curren may have held about the possibility of being an untouched observer of the atrocities around her. It signifies the invasion of violence into her personal space and parallels the irrevocable damage done to the social fabric of South Africa during apartheid.



Mrs. Curren's emotional turmoil upon returning home and her subsequent day of sleep represent a retreat from the overwhelming reality she faced. Her reflections on the past and the deterioration of her country invoke nostalgia for a time of perceived innocence. Again, she is more likely than not seeing the past through rose-colored glasses because she is not of the class or race that would have to deal with the types of issues she recently witnessed.



The following day, the weather is pleasant, and Vercueil drives Mrs. Curren around. When they return home, Vercueil sees two women at her house. One of the women is Florence's sister, who has come to fetch Florence's possessions. Mrs. Curren tries to tell Florence's sister how sorry she is about what happened and writes her a check to give to Florence.

The day after Florence's sister comes to the house, Vercueil asks Mrs. Curren whether "today is the day." Something about the enigmatic questions appears to excite him. Mrs. Curren answers the question affirmatively, but then says the real answer is "no." She says that Vercueil is referencing her plan to commit suicide, which she ultimately decided not to go through with. However, Mrs. Curren does come close to taking her own life. She dresses up nicely for the occasion and tries to mentally prepare herself. When she tells Vercueil that she is having second thoughts, Vercueil offers to drive her around in the car while she thinks about it.

As they drive, Mrs. Curren contemplates how difficult it is to end one's own life, even when one is deeply suffering and there is no hope of getting better. She talks to Vercueil about how lonely she has become since her mother's death and how about how she fears for her country's future. Everything and everyone that once meant something to her has either perished or gone away, leaving her profoundly unhappy.

While the car is stopped, Vercueil gives Mrs. Curren a box of matches and tells her to end her life. When he sees Mrs. Curren is hesitant, he suggests that she drive off a cliff instead. Ultimately, Mrs. Curren decides she wants to live a little longer, so she asks Vercueil to take her home. On the way home, Vercueil asks Mrs. Curren for money to buy alcohol. She gives it to him and when he comes back, he tries to convince her to get drunk. Mrs. Curren resists, but Vercueil insists that the booze is medicine that will help her.

Mrs. Curren gives in and starts drinking. As they drive home, she feels the alcohol loosen her tongue, and she starts trying to tell Vercueil about what happened to Bheki. This leads to a monologue from Mrs. Curren about the suffering of Black people in South Africa. She cannot believe how poorly the government treats Black people without any repercussions. She has never seen so much suffering and dying in her life. Rather than respond to anything she says, Vercueil encourages Mrs. Curren to keep drinking.

The contrast between the pleasant weather and the grim unfolding of events mirrors Mrs. Curren's internal turmoil. Because Mrs. Curren does not know what to do to help Florence, she falls back on the only resource she constantly has access to: money.



Vercueil's seemingly insensitive inquiry about "today being the day" reflects a morbid curiosity about Mrs. Curren's contemplation of suicide, underscoring the detachment and desolation that both characters feel. Additionally, there is something off-putting about Vercueil's eagerness to aid Mrs. Curren in her suicide, perhaps because of his lack of enthusiasm for anything else throughout the rest of the novel.



This moment explores the difficulty to continue living despite profound unhappiness. Mrs. Curren's acknowledgment of her loneliness and the void left by the absence of loved ones casts a light on the deep personal losses that add to the weight of her existential dread.



Mrs. Curren's eventual decision to live "a little longer" indicates a lingering attachment to life, an ambiguous victory over the seductive pull of oblivion. Vercueil's subsequent request for money to buy alcohol and his encouragement for Mrs. Curren to drink can be seen as an attempt to anesthetize the pain, though it is fraught with destructive undertones.



As Mrs. Curren becomes inebriated, her monologue about the suffering of Black South Africans exposes her growing awareness of the systemic injustices of apartheid. The alcohol serves as a catalyst for the release of pent-up emotions and unspoken truths, highlighting the pervasive suffering she has witnessed—and also the fact that she's only now, in her old age, learning just how bad things are for Black South Africans. This highlights her privilege.



Mrs. Curren continues their one-sided conversation. She worries about what is happening to the youth of South Africa. They are growing up fast in a violent world with no hope for a brighter future. She does not see any way out for them or for herself after what she has seen. Again, rather than directly address anything Mrs. Curren says, Vercueil tells her to drink more.

Mrs. Curren's one-sided conversation with Vercueil emphasizes her sense of hopelessness and her acute awareness of the younger generation's grim prospects. Rather than deal with what Mrs. Curren is telling him, Vercueil insists she keep drinking to drown her sorrows—that is, to focus on dealing with the pain these truths cause her, rather than doing anything to help.



Angry that Vercueil will not tackle these issues head on, Mrs. Curren rejects his offer. Vercueil insists that she should use alcohol to numb her pain. In response, Mrs. Curren furiously orders him to get out of her car. Vercueil does as she asks but takes the keys with him and throws them into a nearby bush. Mrs. Curren goes searching for the keys but is unable to locate them.

Mrs. Curren's anger culminating in Vercueil being ordered out of the car signifies a breaking point in her willingness to put up with his apathy. Yet, the throwing of the keys suggests that, despite her desire for autonomy, she is still, in some ways, dependent on or bound to Vercueil.



Now alone, Mrs. Curren thinks about her daughter in America. She wonders if she should have gone to visit her, even though her daughter never asked her to come. The last time she spoke to her daughter over the phone, it was hardly a memorable conversation. Her daughter encouraged her to rest and get better, and Mrs. Curren assured her that she would.

Mrs. Curren loves her daughter, yet they seem to rarely speak and, when they do, their conversations are shallow. As such, the letters Mrs. Curren's daughter will receive upon Mrs. Curren's death will likely be quite shocking to her.



Because she has not told her daughter the truth, Mrs. Curren is stuck trusting Vercueil. Mrs. Curren knows that her daughter will never get the truth if Vercueil fails to send the letters to her, which is a distinct possibility. Mrs. Curren decides that all she can do is trust Vercueil and hope for the best. She also thinks about how much her life has turned upside down since first encountering Vercueil, and she wonders how much he has to do with it.

Mrs. Curren's realization that she must place her trust in Vercueil, an unreliable figure, to communicate her truth to her daughter, is emblematic of the desperation and vulnerability that come with isolation. This reliance on an uncertain intermediary reflects her precarious state, particularly in terms of her health and social isolation.



Mrs. Curren also thinks about her daughter's departure from South Africa. When she left, her daughter told Mrs. Curren that she should not ask her to return to the country until it has improved considerably. Mrs. Curren decided to do exactly as her daughter asked. However, now she feels bitter about agreeing to the deal. Because she does not want her daughter to return to South Africa, Mrs. Curren is forcing herself to suffer and die alone. She openly accuses her daughter of being the cause of her misery.

The bitterness towards her daughter's conditions for returning to South Africa—and Mrs. Curren's subsequent adherence to this stipulation—reveals a deep-seated conflict. Her decision, which now leads to her dying alone, is laden with resentment and a sense of betrayal, highlighting the personal sacrifices made in the name of ideological stances.



A few days pass, and Mrs. Curren catches a cold, which causes her to significant pain. At this point, Vercueil has disappeared again, so she is left on her own. Realizing she needs groceries, she ventures out and manages to get what she needs from the grocery store. However, on the way home, she feels faint from the pain and has to lean up against a lamppost. People ignore her even though she clearly needs help, and she spills much of the food she just purchased. However, eventually she manages to make it home on her own.

That night, Mrs. Curren wakes up to the sound of dogs barking. Downstairs, she hears someone going through her kitchen and wonders if Vercueil has returned. When she goes downstairs, she sees Bheki's friend in her kitchen. Bheki's friend asks Mrs. Curren where he can find Bheki. Frightened, Mrs. Curren calls out for Vercueil. However, Vercueil does not come. After a moment, Mrs. Curren calms down and has a conversation with Bheki's friend about what he wants.

Bheki's friend asks her for money so he can return to Guguletu, but Mrs. Curren tells him to stay away because it is a warzone, and he is likely to get killed. Bheki's friend dismisses her concerns and insists he must get back. Mrs. Curren says she understands his frustration but insists that he stay. She tells him that he must try to resist the violent life that society has seemingly forced upon him. She does not want to tell him what to do—largely because she knows he will not listen—but she promises him more violence is not the answer.

From the moment she first met him, Mrs. Curren disliked Bheki's friend. However, she offers him food and a warm bed because she fears what will happen to him if she lets him go off on his own. Ultimately, the boy decides to stay in Florence's room. Then, Mrs. Curren takes a moment to ponder the letter she's writing to her daughter, which has taken a more abstract tone. She also writes about disturbing dreams that she thinks she is having because of her pain medication. She gets the sense that her life will soon come to an end. Because Vercueil still is not back and she cannot take care of herself, Mrs. Curren decides to call social services to get someone to help deliver her groceries. She does not plan on straying far from her house from now on.

Mrs. Curren's cold and her struggle to manage daily tasks without Vercueil's assistance further illustrate her decline and the indifferent world around her. The public's disregard for her as she leans on a lamppost, vulnerable and in need, is a stark commentary on the erosion of community and compassion in a society fractured by systemic injustice.



Mrs. Curren's life becomes increasingly chaotic and unpredictable following her experience in Guguletu. When Bheki's friend appears again, it suggests that Mrs. Curren can't simply leave behind the events she witnessed in Guguletu: Bheki's friend is a living reminder of the deceased Bheki.



Mrs. Curren's interaction with Bheki's friend, whom she initially disliked, showcases a conflict between self-preservation and empathy. Despite her fear, she offers him sanctuary—a gesture that underscores a humanistic response to his suffering. Her behavior is indicative of the fact that even in dire circumstances, there is room for acts of kindness.



Mrs. Curren's attempt to dissuade Bheki's friend from returning to Guguletu reflects her understanding of the futility and destructiveness of South Africa's violence. She recognizes the young man's autonomy, yet she fears the potential outcomes of the choices available to him in an environment where it's impossible to escape violence. Meanwhile, the abstract tone of Mrs. Curren's letter to her daughter and the disturbing dreams that Mrs. Curren experiences can be seen as manifestations of her internal turmoil.



The following day, Bheki's friend asks Mrs. Curren for antiseptic because he fell off his bike and hurt his head. Mrs. Curren wonders what really happened. She tends to the wound and asks the boy about himself. The boy tells her that his name is John, though Mrs. Curren knows that John is not his real name. John tells Mrs. Curren that he wants to go home. Mrs. Curren reminds him of the situation in Guguletu and how it is unlikely that he has a home left. Ultimately, she convinces John to stay rather than return to the warzone that is Guguletu.

Later the same day, Mrs. Curren catches John doing something suspicious in Florence's room. She watches as he removes a baseboard and stashes something in the floor. She worries that John is hiding weapons in her home, which will get both of them in trouble with the authorities. Mrs. Curren calls Mr. Thabane and expresses her concerns about a possible weapon hidden in her house. She asks Mr. Thabane if someone can come and retrieve John. Mr. Thabane offers vague assurances that someone will come for John eventually. However, he refuses to give her an exact time.

Mrs. Curren and Mr. Thabane's conversation turns philosophical as they discuss their differing perspectives on comradeship, young people's behavior, and the violence in South Africa. Mr. Thabane sees comradeship as a noble quality and is glad that people like John want to fight for their fallen friends. Meanwhile, Mrs. Curren thinks that such loyalty will inevitably end in more violence. Their conversation ends with uncertainty. Mrs. Curren feels sympathy for John and the youth in South Africa and she cries after she is done speaking with Mr. Thabane.

The following morning, Mrs. Curren hears a commotion outside, which initially makes her think that Vercueil is back. However, after listening for a moment, she realizes the voices she hears are speaking Afrikaans. She gets out of bed and goes outside to see what is going on. There, she finds a group of police officers ordering John, who has locked himself in Florence's old room, to come outside and surrender his weapons. Mrs. Curren asks the police to leave the boy and insists he has done nothing wrong. However, the police will not budge. Mrs. Curren asks them if they will guarantee John's safety if she gets him to come outside. Again, the police refuse to give up any ground.

Although Mrs. Curren has known "John" for a long time, this is the first time he gives her a name to call him. The lack of a name previously demonstrated how each character held the other at a distance. Now, they have become closer, but there is still a large divide between them, as John is not the young man's real name. No matter what Mrs. Curren tells him, John does not believe that she has his best interests at heart.



Mr. Thabane's vague assurances and refusal to provide a concrete time for intervention illustrates the uncertainty and unreliability of support systems for someone like John. It mirrors the broader societal context where the authorities are not dependable, and individual people are left to navigate moral decisions in isolation.



Mrs. Curren and Mr. Thabane's philosophical conversation about comradeship and violence reflects the dichotomy between idealism and pragmatism. Mr. Thabane sees value in the youth's solidarity and resistance, while Mrs. Curren predicts this path will only lead to further bloodshed. Their unresolved dialogue mirrors the national conversation about resistance and its consequences during apartheid.



Mrs. Curren's defense of John against the police highlights her empathy and maternal instinct to protect, even as it brings her into direct conflict with the authorities. Meanwhile, John will not leave his room because he knows that his life could be over if he does. Until the bitter end, he resists state authority at all costs because of what he has experienced in his life. As John suspects, the police do not care about his safety; they simply want to persecute him.



A female officer tells Mrs. Curren that she will need to leave her house for a few days until the situation is settled. However, Mrs. Curren refuses to leave her home to the police. Because she will not leave, one of the police officers picks her up, causing her to cry out in pain. Mrs. Curren tells them she has **cancer** and orders them to put her down immediately. The police exchange a look and a smile, as if they think Mrs. Curren is senile. Mrs. Curren assures them that her pain is real and that they will experience something similar one day. From the other room, Mrs. Curren hears the sound of breaking glass followed by several gunshots.

Shortly afterwards, an ambulance arrives, and the female officer tells Mrs. Curren she needs to leave. Mrs. Curren, disoriented and without her medication, wanders off on her own and falls asleep under a bridge. While in a fugue state, several young boys accost her looking for money. Scared, weak, and confused, she urinates. Sometime later, the boys return to probe her mouth for gold teeth. When they are done, they kick dirt over her face. The entire time, Mrs. Curren fades in and out of consciousness.

Mrs. Curren wakes up to find Vercueil's dog licking her face. Vercueil himself appears on the scene moments later and carries her home. Surprisingly, Mrs. Curren's pain becomes more bearable in his presence. She confesses she does not want to return home but accompanies Vercueil to a secluded spot under a bridge. They have a one-sided conversation where Mrs. Curren discusses her views on South Africa's situation and her own moral conflicts. When Mrs. Curren stops talking, she looks over and finds that Vercueil has fallen asleep. When he wakes up, Mrs. Curren suggests that they go home.

Upon returning home, Mrs. Curren and Vercueil find her house in disarray. An officer who is still on the scene informs her that detectives are on the way. Mrs. Curren lies down, and the officer questions Vercueil about someone named "Johannes" (which is presumably John's real name). Mrs. Curren falsely claims ownership of the pistol that the detectives found in John's room and insists Vercueil is her right-hand man.

The officer warns Mrs. Curren that keeping an unregistered weapon is against the law, and she could get in a lot of trouble. Mrs. Curren dismisses the officer's fake concern and tells him that everyone needs a weapon nowadays because of what South Africa has become. After the officer leaves, Mrs. Curren leaves a message for Mr. Thabane on his answering machine, warning him to be careful. Then, she lies in bed and thinks about what happened to John. She wants to write but feels that she does not have the strength.

The officers' treatment of Mrs. Curren showcases the disregard for personal dignity and the elderly by those in power. Even though Mrs. Curren is a white woman, the officers do not care about violating her rights because they feel that persecuting John is more important. The breaking glass and gunshots suggest a violent resolution to the standoff with John.



Mrs. Curren's disorientation and vulnerability under the bridge illustrate her alienation and the breakdown of societal protections for the weak and sick. Her mistreatment by the boys searching for gold teeth is a powerful metaphor for the exploitation and degradation faced by those deemed powerless or irrelevant.



Vercueil's return and his aid to Mrs. Curren highlight an odd form of companionship that has developed between them—one marked by necessity, chance encounters, and unspoken understanding. Mrs. Curren's pain lessening in Vercueil's presence suggests the comfort that can come from even the most unlikely sources. Meanwhile, the one-sided conversation under the bridge reflects the burden Mrs. Curren feels, now that she knows more about apartheid's horrors.



Upon returning home, the chaos and the police's continued presence underscore state's invasion of Mrs. Curren's private life. Mrs. Curren refuses to give the detective the information he is looking for as a small act of rebellion against a system she has now come to realize is broken, unfair, and deeply exploitative.



Mrs. Curren's decision to leave a message for Mr. Thabane warns of the dangers still present, and it demonstrates that she still wishes to be of use to other people, even in her weakened state. However, her inability to write suggests that her days are numbered, and she will not be able to help anyone in the near future.



CHAPTER 4

Mrs. Curren has a dream where she envisions Florence walking with Hope and Beauty down Government Avenue. In this dream, Mrs. Curren puts on a circus act, but Florence pays no attention to her. As the dream unfolds, Mrs. Curren performs fire tricks, and she notices Florence looking like a goddess, dressed in a white slip with bare feet. Florence is pointing toward something, but Mrs. Curren cannot see what it is. Then, Mrs. Curren becomes engulfed in blue flames.

Upon waking, Mrs. Curren shares her dream with Vercueil, and she says that everything in the dream symbolizes something else. She expresses her reluctance to go to the hospital, fearing they will put her in a drug-induced coma, depriving her of dreaming. She feels that her dreams are one of the few deeply meaningful parts of her life that she has left, and she wants to hold on to them.

Later, Mrs. Curren asks Vercueil to fix her radio, but he suggests bringing in a TV instead. Mrs. Curren rejects his offer, but he brings in the TV anyway. Together, they watch as the South African anthem plays and a blue flag waves in the background. The display of nationalism irritates Mrs. Curren, and she tells Vercueil to turn off the television. Instead, Vercueil turns up the volume and dances to the anthem, infuriating her further. Vercueil eventually switches it off, reassuring her that the turmoil in South Africa will end soon. He also tells Mrs. Curren that she needs to lighten up and allow herself to have fun.

Later, Mrs. Curren reflects on her desire not to be put into a drug-induced sleep, as sleep provides her only respite from suffering. The same day, she loses consciousness and then awakens from a bout of apparent madness, scribbling on the walls. Thinking she must have had an adverse reaction to her medication, she calls her doctor and requests a new prescription. Her doctor tells her that she should come see him if she wants to receive proper care. However, Mrs. Curren insists upon staying in her home and once again asks for a new prescription. Eventually, the doctor gives in and writes her the prescription she wants. However, he warns her that the new pills may not help and that she needs to come to hospital if she does not want the end of her life to become a nightmare.

Mrs. Curren's dream of performing tricks unnoticed encapsulates her feelings of invisibility and the sense of her actions being inconsequential. Her engulfment in blue flames could symbolize her newfound place fighting for change in South Africa, which is full of violence and destruction. Additionally, she may not live to see the end of apartheid.



Mrs. Curren's reluctance to go to the hospital, for fear of being deprived of her dreams, reflects a desire to maintain autonomy over her consciousness and to cling to the profound experiences she feels have changed her over the last few months. Perhaps it is also a protest against an institution that she has witnessed failing Black South Africans first-hand (as when the hospital didn't treat John's injuries properly).



The introduction of the TV and the anthem playing in the background is jarring to Mrs. Curren, who has started to deeply question the values and ethics of her country. Vercueil's suggestion to lighten up and his dance to the anthem can be interpreted as either a form of mockery or a coping mechanism to deal with the pervasive atmosphere of nationalism and propaganda. That is, he acts absurdly because he views the word as absurd.



Mrs. Curren's episode of "madness" and her subsequent call to the doctor illustrate her desperation to maintain control over her life and her distrust of institutional care. Her insistence on staying in her home and managing her pain with medication underscores her need for independence and her fear of becoming a passive recipient of care in her final days. She wants to maintain control over her life for as long as she possibly can without being a burden to other people.



Mrs. Curren receives the new pills, but, as the doctor suggested might happen, they offer little relief. Mrs. Curren questions Vercueil about why he chose her, and he responds that he didn't choose her. She inquires why he came to her house, and he explains it was because she didn't have a dog and wouldn't cause trouble. In a tense moment, Vercueil briefly puts his hands around her throat, suggesting that he could end her suffering at any moment. The thought of her death makes Mrs. Curren sob. After pulling herself together, she asks if Vercueil's dog can sleep in her bed for warmth, but Vercueil insists the dog only sleeps where he does. Mrs. Curren suggests Vercueil sleep in her bed as well. He agrees to the arrangement and climbs into the bed. The dog jumps up as well to sleep between them.

Mrs. Curren gradually learns more about Vercueil's past, including his hand injury and experiences in Russia and China. Concerned about his future, she discusses what will happen to him after her death. She promises to watch over him in the afterlife if that is a possibility. Mrs. Curren expresses worry about Vercueil's ability to care for himself, mentioning his unusual food preferences. However, Vercueil himself is largely unconcerned. He thinks he will be able to continue on, just as he always has.

Every night, Vercueil and his dog sleep by Mrs. Curren's side to help keep her warm. Vercueil also helps her with household chores and tries to soothe her when she is in pain. Mrs. Curren tells Vercueil about how she used to be a classics teacher in her younger years. She quotes him some lines from Virgil, which pique Vercueil's interest. He asks her if she would be willing to help him learn Latin. Mrs. Curren tells him she would be happy to teach him with what time she has left. However, she knows there is much he will not have time to learn because her death is near. She regrets not having more time to teach Vercueil.

Mrs. Curren considers asking Vercueil to deliver her papers to her daughter in the United States in person but knows he won't agree to it. Mrs. Curren reflects on her lack of connection with her grandchildren and her general feelings of loneliness. She regrets that she does not know more about her daughter's life and desperately wishes they were together. She also thinks that Vercueil is lonely like her, and she regrets not being able to provide him with more companionship.

Vercueil's strange presence in Mrs. Curren's life becomes more understandable when he responds to her inquiries about his choice to stay with her. His explanation that he chose her house because she "wouldn't cause trouble" implies that he chose her because he identified her as a potential pushover, yet their relationship develops into something complex and significant. The tense moment where Vercueil places his hands around her throat brings their relationship to a critical point, confronting the possibility of her death directly and violently.



Mrs. Curren's concern for Vercueil's future and her promise to watch over him in the afterlife reveal her maternal instincts and her desire to leave a lasting, positive impact on someone's life. Despite Vercueil's nonchalant attitude toward survival, Mrs. Curren's worry for him signifies her need to find some form of legacy in the care and concern for another person.



The arrangement for Vercueil and his dog to sleep in Mrs. Curren's bed suggests an intimacy and companionship that transcends their initial interactions and reflects a mutual need for physical and emotional warmth. Similarly, Mrs. Curren's teachings are also mutually beneficial; she gets to do something that gives her life meaning and Vercueil appears genuinely interested in what she has to say.



Mrs. Curren's contemplation of sending Vercueil to deliver papers to her daughter in the United States reflects her hope that she could reconcile with her daughter before her death. Yet, her understanding of Vercueil's likely refusal to undertake such a task underscores a sense of resignation to the broken lines of communication within her family.



One night, Mrs. Curren wakes up feeling cold. She finds that Vercueil is not in her bed. Instead, he is standing on the balcony attached to her bedroom, allowing the wind to blow into her room. She asks Vercueil what he is looking at, but he does not respond. Then, she asks him, "Is it time?" Again, Vercueil does not respond. Instead, he approaches the bed and forcibly embraces her. The breath rushes out of Mrs. Curren, and she feels no warmth in his embrace.

The coldness Mrs. Curren feels upon waking and finding Vercueil standing on the balcony introduces a physical manifestation of the emotional chill that has characterized many of her recent experiences. Her question, "Is it time?" is loaded with significance—questioning whether it is time for her death, time for some revelation, or simply time for Vercueil to return to bed. Vercueil's non-response and subsequent cold embrace suggest that her death is near.





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